



‘EXTREMIST AMBUSH’
Abducted man found dead in Manipur

NEWS » PAGE 4

IMPROVEMENTS PROPOSED

Services ‘review’
Agnipath as tenure of first batch ends

NEWS » PAGE 4



FOCUS ON NEGOTIATIONS
No military solution to war, says Iran Minister

WORLD » PAGE 14

UNILATERAL DECISIONS

An appalling state of affairs
Election Commission’s conduct of SIR raises serious questions

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



IRANI CUP
Mukesh and Akash bowl Rol to victory

SPORT » PAGE 17

INSIDE



Campaigning for byelections ends in 3 States, 1 UT.

NEW DELHI
The campaign for byelections to five Assembly constituencies in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Puducherry, as well as to one Lok Sabha constituency in Assam, ended at 5 p.m. on Sunday. Polling for these constituencies will take place on Tuesday, and the counting of votes is scheduled for Friday. » PAGE 4

Sailor held for leaking data to Pakistani spy

VISAKHAPATNAM
The Counter Intelligence Cell of the Andhra Pradesh Police has arrested a 31-year-old Navy sailor for allegedly leaking classified maritime information to a Pakistani intelligence operative through a social media honey trap. He joined the Indian Navy in 2014 and is now posted in the Eastern Naval Command in Visakhapatnam. » PAGE 4

Two pregnant women die in Bihar hospital

PATNA
Two pregnant women died on Sunday in Bihar’s Jamui Sadar Hospital allegedly due to a lack of care as doctors were unavailable. Family members accused the doctors of negligence and staged a protest. Tension rose after Minister Shreyasi Singh visited the hospital and condemned its management. A video of the incident went viral. » PAGE 6

Merz announces aid for Ukraine during Kyiv visit

KYIV
German Chancellor Friedrich Merz announced a new aid package for Ukraine worth more than \$1.5 billion during a visit to Kyiv on Sunday, as Russia escalated its attacks on Ukrainian cities. About \$1.1 billion of the package is military aid, including long-range strike weapons, combat drones and satellite technology, he said. » PAGE 14

Bengal govt. will legislate against ‘love, land jihad’

KOLKATA
West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Sunday said he would bring stringent laws against “love jihad”, “land jihad”, and religious conversion after the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) is implemented. “The UCC will be implemented soon,” he said at an event marking the birth centenary of VHP’s former chief, the late Ashok Singhal. » PAGE 6

Over 500 held amid stir against CEC in Delhi

Police clash with protesters trying to reach the heavily barricaded Jantar Mantar protest area

The BJP is using the CEC to ‘take away our right to vote’, Uddhav Thackeray says at rally in Mumbai

AISA’s chief Neha Bora says we showed we are citizens despite abuse and ‘arbitrary detention’

Lavpreet Kaur
Chinmay Gaikwad
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Protests seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and the suspension of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls entered their third day on Sunday, with demonstrations continuing in New Delhi and Mumbai.

The protests, which began on October 2, included leaders of Opposition parties, civil society activists, and members of youth and student organisations.

On Sunday, confrontations took place in New Delhi between protesters, who were trying to reach Jantar Mantar, and the Delhi Police, who had heavily barricaded the area. The police stopped the march on Ashoka Road and detained nearly 500 people.

In Mumbai, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Nav-



Police trying to stop All India Students’ Association leader Neha Bora who climbed a barricade as protesters attempt to march towards Jantar Mantar on Sunday. PTI

nirman Sena chief Raj Thackeray led a march seeking the CEC’s removal and the scrapping of the ongoing SIR drive. The Shiv Sena (UBT) chief described the CEC as a “weapon” in the hands of the Bharatiya Janata Party and claimed that the ruling party was using Mr. Kumar to

“take away the right to vote”. “You can control institutions, but streets belong to us,” Mr. Uddhav Thackeray said, adding that the removal of “around 13 crore names” from draft rolls across the country amounted to disenfranchisement.

Several videos of con-

frontations between protesters and the police in New Delhi were circulated on social media, one of which showed protesters breaking the rear window of a bus and jumping out.

The All India Students’ Association (AISA) alleged that its national president, Neha Bora, was picked up

Disenfranchising people a violative act, says SC judge

NEW DELHI
Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday said any process disenfranchising millions, making them second class citizens without the right to vote, was intrinsically arbitrary, and violative of universal adult suffrage and right to equality. Speaking at NALSAR in Hyderabad, he said no amount of whataboutery could justify such massive exclusion as it was fatal to the Constitution. » PAGE 5

Karnataka BJP agent booked for Form 7 misuse

BENGALURU
A first information report (FIR) has been registered against a booth-level agent of the BJP in Karnataka after he repeatedly attempted to file Form 7 applications for deletion of over 7,500 electors in the Ballari City constituency, claiming they were either “absent or had shifted”. The names of all these electors are present in the draft voters’ list. This is the sixth FIR being filed for Form 7 misuse. » PAGE 3

nal and criminal. It should go.”

Mumbai march
MNS chief Raj Thackeray sought the CEC’s removal and called for electronic voting machines to be replaced with ballot papers. Terming the SIR drive “illegal”, he questioned the “rise” in the number of voters between the 2024 Lok Sabha election and the Maharashtra Assembly poll later that year.

He asked the commission to state how many of those left out of the draft rolls had been identified as immigrants from Bangladesh. “Are the 2 crore people from Bangladesh? Give details. We will throw them out of the country,” he said.

Leaders from the Congress and the Nationalist Congress Party-Sharadchandra Pawar (NCP-SP) also participated in the ‘Virat Garjana Morcha’ held in Mumbai that drew nearly 6,000 participants.

Country regimen



Youth take part in a race through a field at the Suragiri Temple, on the outskirts of Mangaluru, on Sunday PTI

Talking to both Kyiv, Moscow: Jaishankar

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India is going “beyond advocacy” on the Russia-Ukraine conflict, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said on Sunday, indicating for the first time that New Delhi is involved in conveying messages between Moscow and Kyiv on agreements for maritime safety in the Black Sea and grain export.

Speaking at a German think-tank’s event, Mr. Jaishankar responded to questions about India’s close ties with Russia by pointing out that Moscow has “stood by India” in difficult times. He suggested that other countries could seek to build coalitions to work on issues like international peace and security.



S. Jaishankar

“We have conversations with both Russia and Ukraine [on the need for dialogue and diplomacy],” Mr. Jaishankar said at the Munich Leaders Meeting in Delhi on Sunday. “We are trying to be helpful, starting with the Black Sea safety of shipping issue, but going beyond that to cover some immediate concerns which both of them have on grain exports, on energy exports, on non-attack possi-

bilities. So those are ongoing conversations right now,” he added.

Mr. Jaishankar’s strong defence of India-Russia ties suggests New Delhi will not reduce its Russian oil purchases, which currently account for over 50% of India’s oil imports, even in the face of possible U.S. sanctions under a new law enacted on September 18.

‘U.S. is a lonelier power’
“For [India,] Russia, and the Soviet Union before that, was a country that stood by us in many ways when our security, when our territorial integrity was under threat, and at a time when you know much of the world preferred backing a military regime next to us,” he said, referring to Soviet support during the

1971 India-Pakistan war and the liberation of Bangladesh.

He referred to the “changing global landscape” as a cause for concern. “The landscape today is primarily marked by a radical repositioning of the United States. A repositioning which is a posture of choice, and where in a way it has deliberately become a lonelier power,” he said, adding that another feature of the ‘landscape’ is the “rise of China, which sees itself as a unique country that it is in a way...and we are looking at very sharp competition...that has led to a weaponisation of any leverage that any country has.”

MEETING WITH PAPARO
» PAGE 6

Keralam orders corruption investigation against CEC

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Amid protests seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government in Keralam on Sunday sought to revive a 20-year-old corruption allegation against him, when he was the State’s Public Works Department (PWD) Secretary, by ordering a preliminary inquiry by the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB).

Keralam Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala’s office told *The Hindu* that the Minister had ordered VACB Director Manoj Abraham to investigate the accusation that persistent efforts to extort bribes from PATI-BEL consortium, an Indo-Malaysian construction firm contracted to upgrade the Main Central (MC) Road under the Kerala State Transport Project, had caused inordinate delays and cost escalations, allegedly resulted in significant losses to the exchequer and the suspected death by suicide of Lee See Been, the project’s chief engineer, in Kuala Lumpur, in November 2006.

Officials said the Home Department has also sought the Crime Branch’s findings from its 2006 probe into the accusations, for legal opinion, adding that Mr. Chennithala ordered the inquiry after Congress leader Malayankutty Venugopal filed a complaint. Notably, the Indo-Malaysian firm was contracted by a previous UDF government led by the Congress.

Officials said Mr. Chennithala had also directed the VACB to re-examine the findings of an earlier vigilance inquiry ordered by former Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan after the Lee See Been controversy, which prompted the removal of Mr. Gyanesh Kumar as the State’s PWD Secretary.



Mounting trouble: The allegation is related to a road contract when Gyanesh Kumar was the Kerala PWD Secretary. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

nithala had also directed the VACB to re-examine the findings of an earlier vigilance inquiry ordered by former Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan after the Lee See Been controversy, which prompted the removal of Mr. Gyanesh Kumar as the State’s PWD Secretary.

‘Incriminating charges’
Mr. Venugopal, in his petition to Mr. Chennithala, had argued that the 2006 enquiries against Mr. Kumar circumvented due process and ignored the “incriminating accusations” in Been’s purported suicide note.

He also accused the then Left Democratic Front (LDF) dispensation of quietly scuttling the probe against Mr. Kumar and opening the door for the IAS officer to seek Central deputation.

Officials said the Keralam Home Department had also factored in the “damning findings” of the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG), who evaluated the initial phase of the MC Road augmentation works by the firm, in order-

ing the VACB inquiry.

They said the CAG had faulted the PWD for releasing significant interest-free advances to PATI-BEL “without proper field audit of the road work’s progress”.

The CAG, they said, also blamed the PWD for administrative incompetence, inordinate delays in approving part bills, holding up road re-design proposals, and “dubiously” citing cost escalation to restructure the contract terms and agreement, allegedly in favour of the construction company.

Home Department officials said the CAG had pegged the loss to the State treasury at an estimated ₹92 crore, laying the legal groundwork for a renewed anti-corruption inquiry.

(If in distress or having suicidal tendencies, please reach out to these helplines: TeleMANAS at 1-8008914416/ 14416, NIMHANS at 08026685948, 9480829670 or SAHAI at 080 25497777, +91-9886444075).

SUICIDE ABETMENT CASE
» PAGE 3

INBRIEF



U.P.'s Bhadohi district renamed
Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday announced that Bhadohi district has now been renamed as Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi. The Chief Minister was addressing a gathering in Bhadohi after he inaugurated and laid the foundation stones for 112 projects worth over ₹1,340 crore. “On the occasion of Guru Purnima, we had said that Bhadohi district, currently known for its carpet industry, would in the future be known by the name of Satguru Ravidas ji Maharaj, a medieval saint who united society through his spiritual devotion,” Mr. Adityanath said.

Cong. leaders held for defacing
CEC’s house released on bail

Six Congress leaders accused of allegedly writing slogans with black paint on the gate and outer wall of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar’s residence in Agra were released from the Agra district jail on Sunday, a day after a local court granted them bail. The six leaders - Mukesh Dhangar, Anil Yadav, Rajesh Kumar, Manoj Gaur, Rajesh Gautam, and Pankaj Chaudhary - were arrested on September 29 in connection with the defacement incident in the Vijay Nagar area a day earlier. The court granted them bail on Saturday after the police dropped the attempt to murder charge during the investigation. PTI

Police prevent
protesters
from entering
SRFTI campus

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

Chaos unfolded outside the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) here on Sunday during a protest by members of the Bangiya Hindu Jagaran Mancha as police prevented them from entering the campus. The protest was held against the September 27 clash on the campus between students and an RSS-affiliated group.

SPOTLIGHT

Satyasundar Barik

For 35 years, Balunkeswar Paikray has travelled hundreds of kilometres and knocked on the doors of every authority he could think of. He even reached out to the Prime Minister and touched the feet of local government officials in the hope that someone would listen. The 55-year-old visually impaired man from Odisha’s Khordha district says, “I am not asking for charity. I am fighting for a rightful share in my ancestral property.” Paikray says his share among his three siblings would amount to 40,000 square feet of paternal property in Khordha’s Kadab village. “Now, I live in less than 300 square feet,” he says of his room, bathroom, and backyard. His long struggle has given him a painful insight into how the world treats those who cannot see, walk, or behave in what is considered regular. His battle has revealed how a disability can deepen a person’s vulnerability, strip away social standing and, in the maze of bureaucracy and family rows, reduce an individual to almost a non-entity. In August, the Odisha government formulated a comprehensive set of guidelines to safeguard the property and inheritance

rights of persons with disabilities (PwDs) under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. Paikray and lakhs of others saw hope. The move was also welcomed by those working in the disability sector, who see it as a significant step towards protecting PwDs from discrimination in matters of property, including ancestral, inherited, and self-acquired. The three-page guidelines suggested that the Revenue and Disaster Management Department examine the feasibility of issuing comprehensive guidelines and instructions to all revenue authorities to safeguard the land and property rights of PwDs.

Key proposals One of the key proposals is to maintain a register of complaints relating to the property rights of PwDs at the tehsil and Sub-Collector levels, with periodic monitoring by the District Collector. Activists say while revenue laws provide safeguards for Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities - including prior permission for transfer of land or property to persons from the general category - PwDs remain more vulnerable and require similar protection. In August, the Odisha government’s Suresh Kumar Vashishth wrote to Arabinda Kumar Padhee to issue comprehensive guidelines that would protect

Our focus should be on
winning U.P. election not
seat allocation: Akhilesh

His remarks come amid the continuing war of words between leaders of SP and Congress over sharing of seats; SP MP had earlier said that Congress should not expect more than 50 seats

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday said how many seats which party contested was not as important as ensuring that the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc won the Uttar Pradesh Assembly election, due early in 2027.

The motivation should be that communalism never raises its head again, and democracy, the Constitution of India, and reservations were not harmed by the divisive Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), so that harmony blossomed again in the country, Mr. Yadav said.

“When the purpose is clear, it goes hand in hand. If your eyes are on the destination, the journey becomes easy. The important thing is not how many seats are in the alliance or which seat is going to



Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi with Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav in New Delhi. FILE PHOTO

whom; the important thing is that we all have to ensure the alliance wins. Let us repeat again: it is not about the seat but about the victory. This victory will be more than the victory of the parties in our alliance. It will be the victory of the joint effort of all of us, the victory of continuous struggle, so that communalism can never raise its head again, and democracy, the Constitution, and reservation are not harmed by the BJP, and the harmony of the country,

the progress and prosperity of the country, blossoms again,” Mr. Yadav posted on X.

However, a war of words on seat-sharing and the number of seats the Congress would contest in the 2027 U.P. Assembly election, continued between the SP and Congress leaders.

U.P. Congress in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam took on SP Lok Sabha MP Shivpal Singh Patel’s statement that the Congress should not expect more than 50

seats to contest. “Then he (Mr. Patel) should refuse – he should clearly say that he does not want to form an alliance. At least the matter should be fair. What was the need to make such a light statement?” Mr. Gautam said.

Uttar Pradesh has a 403-member Assembly.

“Both the parties will win and form the government in an alliance. When have we talked about defeat? We too are talking about victory. It is not one person who wins the election, but the parties. The public votes for a party. There are one or two people with such a high stature and so well-liked by the electorate that they can even win independently. Otherwise, the party fights the election and the party wins the election. Elections are fought on the basis of ideology. In terms of ideology, the Congress party is number one in the entire country,” Mr. Gautam said.

Badal appeals to people to elect him
Punjab CM for ‘speedy development’

Press Trust of India
AMARGARH

Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) chief Sukhbir Singh Badal on Sunday appealed to Punjab voters to choose the right Chief Minister to take the State forward, asserting if they wanted speedy development, coupled with new age agriculture and employment models, he was “most fit” for the post.

Addressing a ‘Punjab Bachao’ rally here, Mr. Badal congratulated the party’s new constituency in-charge Jassi Manvi. He also ap-

pealed to voters to ensure Mr. Jassi’s victory in the upcoming Assembly poll.

Mann criticised

Saying Punjabis deserved a Chief Minister who can deliver, Mr. Badal said, “Both [former CMs] Capt. Amarinder and Bhagwant Mann have failed you. Bhagwant Mann has not only failed to keep his promises but is also playing a cruel joke on you by trying to regale you with jokes instead of resolving serious issues like the drug menace and collapse of law and order.”

He said the lack of seriousness of the competitors for the Chief Minister’s post in 2027 election can be seen in the claims they make. “Charanjit Singh Channi asserts that he can milk goats while Bhagwant Mann brags he can repair a cycle tyre puncture in the dark,” Mr. Badal jibed, saying people can consider voting for them if they expect their leaders to perform such tasks.

“If you want to put Punjab back on the track of development, then I am the man for you,” he said.

Dipankar questions Speaker over convicted
Bihar BJP legislator’s continued membership

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya on Sunday questioned why there has been no decision on Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MLA Raju Singh’s membership despite being convicted in a celebratory firing case that led to the death of a woman.

Mr. Bhattacharya said in the case of CPI(ML) MLA Manoj Manzil, a different approach was adopted and



CPI(ML) general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya ANI

his membership was immediately terminated following conviction in a murder case. Mr. Bhattacharya sought an answer and raised questions about the

Farmers block key
highway over ‘tardy’
paddy procurement

Press Trust of India
YAMUNANAGAR

Farmers on Sunday blocked a stretch of the Panchkula-Saharanpur highway at Aurangabad village in Yamunanagar district alleging tardy paddy procurement by the Haryana government. They later opened it following talks with local authorities.

Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU) national spokesperson Rakesh Tikait, who was present on the spot, told reporters that what else can a farmer do if the government does not procure his grain.

“First, the Haryana government said the procurement will start on September 25. Then it gave another date - September 29. The farmers are facing problems as their foodgrains are not being procured,” Mr. Tikait said.

“These are the same farmers who surrounded Delhi for 13 months (during the protest against the now-repealed farm laws). They should not be harassed in the name of procurement,” he said.

“Whatever decisions the farmers of Haryana take, BKU will stand by them,” Mr. Tikait said. Earlier, the



Rakesh Tikait

BKU organised a Kisan Mahapanchayat at Aurangabad to discuss farmers’ issues.

Cong. alleges delay Congress’ Haryana in-charge Sanjay Dutt and the party’s State unit president Rao Narender Singh on Sunday visited the grain market in Karnal and took stock of paddy procurement arrangements.

Mr. Dutt said farmers across Haryana are reaching markets with their produce, but are struggling to sell their crops. In some places, procurement is being delayed, while in others, lifting arrangements have broken down, Mr. Dutt said, asserting that Congress will strongly raise farmers’ issues from the streets to the assembly.

The right to more than
a room and roof

The Odisha govt. has framed guidelines to safeguard the property rights of persons with disabilities. Activists say the rules are needed for both inherited and self-acquired property, and can help improve lives



Balunkeswar Paikray, a visually impaired resident of Kadab village in Khordha district, has spent three decades fighting to reclaim his share of inherited property. He has approached several authorities, including the Prime Minister, but says his efforts are yet to yield a resolution. BISWARANJAN ROUT

all PwDs’ rights over inherited and self-acquired property. Vashishth is Principal Secretary to the Department of Social Security and Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities; Padhee is Additional Chief Secretary, Revenue and Disaster Management Department, under which property is registered.

The guidelines were formulated based on the 2016 Act, particularly Sections 12, 13, 84, and 85. These cast an obligation upon the government to ensure pro-

tection of the rights, property, legal capacity, and the interests of PwDs and to prevent all forms of abuse, violence, exploitation, and discrimination. Vashishth suggested immediate inquiry upon receipt of complaints relating to illegal occupation, encroachment, cultivation, mutation, or alienation of lands belonging to PwDs and strict monitoring of these properties. He suggested capacity building and sensitisation of revenue officers to the rights of

persons with disabilities under the Act, and the need for adopting disability-sensitive procedures. Bratati Harichandan, State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, says this is an inter-departmental effort. “We have requested the Panchayati Raj Department to sensitise officials at the grassroots so that persons with disabilities are accommodated under government housing schemes and assured of a roof over their heads, particularly when they are

forced out of their own homes,” Harichandan says.

The struggle

Milan Kumar Das, 45, his brother Chandan, and sister Mamata, from Bhadrak district, all of whom have 100% locomotor disabilities, are easy targets for those determined to usurp legally inherited property.

Confined to a cramped 100-square-foot room, the siblings and their 80-year-old mother depend on each other for survival. Together, they receive about ₹14,000 a month in disability and other pensions, while subsidised rice keeps hunger at bay. What weighs on them most is not poverty, but the loss of property that they say should have been theirs.

“Our father was an employee of Indian Oil Corporation. He had purchased land and built a house here [in Nadigaon village in Bhadrak district]. After his death, we were driven out by other members of the joint family. Only after police intervention, were we given a tiny room as shelter,” Milan says, adding that for nearly 10 years, he and his siblings appealed to the Bhadrak district administration and police seeking justice.

In Jaipur district, Prakash Mohapatra, 48, who is visually impaired, worries about his future. “Now I live with my mother and brother in the village,” he says, fearing the situation

will change with time. “My repeated applications for a house under the Prime Minister Awas Yojana have not led anywhere, the application is stuck in some government office.”

Manjulata Panda, 49, Odisha’s first visually impaired woman to earn a PhD and now a lecturer in a college in Sambalpur district, is fighting to get the family property registered in her and her brother’s names. He too is visually impaired and is a teacher in a government primary school. “Since both of us have good jobs, we don’t struggle for food or survival. But our ancestral properties are entangled in a procedural mess. We are not able to record it in our name,” Panda says. In Panda’s case, no one else has claimed the land, but she says there are “procedural hurdles” that the government must help with.

The State government’s move came after Dr. Arabinda Mohanty, a paediatrician by profession and an activist on disability for more than three decades, highlighted the plight of people with physical and intellectual disabilities.

In 2025, he wrote to the State Commission for Persons with Disabilities to take up the issue with the government, insisting on the need for such guidelines. “I have come across numerous cases of discrimination against intellectually challenged and

physically challenged persons. Invariably, they don’t get the rightful share of their ancestral property,” says Mohanty.

Redressal of grievances

Shruti Mohapatra, 63, a disability rights activist who is herself a person with orthopaedic disability, says those with intellectual disabilities are among the most vulnerable when it comes to the transfer and protection of property rights. “To some extent, those with visual, hearing, and orthopaedic disabilities can raise their voices against discrimination or injustice. But persons with intellectual disabilities are largely dependent on their parents or trusted legal guardians,” she says.

Mohapatra also points to the lack of disability-friendly facilities in the justice system. “While society often ignores and disowns persons with intellectual disabilities, the government has also failed to ensure adequate employment opportunities for them,” says Kartik Chandra Pandab, secretary of Rourkela-based voluntary organisation Shradha Foundation, which works in the disability sector.

Meanwhile, Paikray hopes the State government’s guidelines will finally help him claim his share of property.

satyasundar.b
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Fake death records used for deletion; inquiry ordered

BJP questions
Rahul's silence
on valour of
Captain Smit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday questioned the Congress over what it termed the Opposition party's "silence" on Indian pilot Smit Machchhar, who thwarted his co-pilot's alleged attempt to crash a Tel Aviv-bound fly-dubai flight.

Rajya Sabha MP and BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi termed the lack of a statement from the Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on the incident as, "the Gandhi family's silent support to terrorism".

"Rahul Gandhi, the wayward prince of the Gandhi family, who was once so distressed over Gaza, seems to be so terrified of the vote bank that he is not able to utter a single word to hail the valour of Captain Smit Machchhar," Mr. Trivedi said, demanding a response from the Congress' top leadership.

"Sonia Gandhi, the *raj-mata* (queen mother) of the first family, whose eyes once welled up with tears for the accused (killed) in the Batla House encounter, has shown no trace of compassion for Captain Smit. The princess (an apparent reference to Priyanka Gandhi Vadra), who used to carry a bag bearing the Palestinian cause, has failed to produce even a handkerchief of sympathy from it," he added.

'En masse exclusion of
voters unconstitutional'

Any process that disenfranchises millions, making them second class citizens, is arbitrary, says Justice Bhuyan; name of voter cannot be deleted from the roll without notice or hearing, he says

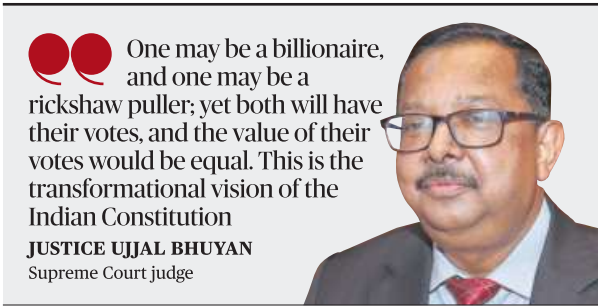
Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday said any process disenfranchising millions, making them second class citizens without the right to vote, was intrinsically arbitrary, and violative of universal adult suffrage and right to equality.

Speaking at NALSAR, Hyderabad, Justice Bhuyan said no amount of whataboutery could justify the exclusion of voters *en masse* from the electoral rolls as such an action was fatal to the Constitution.

The Election Commission's special intensive revision (SIR) has so far led to the deletion of approximately 13.3 crore voters from the electoral rolls.

Recently, former Supreme Court judge, Justice Rohinton F. Nariman, had drawn attention to the "astounding figure" of 90 lakh disenfranchised voters in West Bengal itself, questioning why the figure did not prompt the Supreme Court to stay the special intensive revision process. He had termed the exclusion of voters and delay in deciding their appeals "a completely illegal knocking out of the common man, the citizen of India,



in order that a government obtains what it wants".

Justice Bhuyan said the Constitution did not provide for two classes of citizens – those with voting rights and citizens without voting rights.

"Any process which leads to wholesale disenfranchisement of Indian citizens making them citizens without voting rights would be violative of Articles 326 (adult suffrage) and 14 (right to equality) of the Constitution, if any process results in disenfranchising millions and millions of Indian citizens making them second class citizens in their own country in the sense of being citizens without voting rights, such a process is intrinsically arbitrary. No amount of whataboutery can justify it. It strikes at the very heart of the Constitution," he said.

Justice Bhuyan said no one could tinker with universal adult suffrage. "No

authority can do it; no court can condone it. No one is above the Constitution. Indian citizens' right to vote is intertwined with India's long years of struggle for freedom," he said.

Constitutional right

The judge said the right to be a voter was not merely a statutory right, but a constitutional right which came within the framework of the Basic Structure of the Constitution.

He said citizenship and franchise were intertwined, and one could not be divorced from the other. The right of franchise was the very essence of citizenship. It was the only way an ordinary citizen of India could participate in the governance of the country.

"Universal adult franchise is the right of every adult citizen to vote, free of qualifications of sex, race, religion, wealth, education or social status, subject only to narrow, reasoned ex-

ceptions... Except in the case of a dead voter, the name of a voter once enlisted in the electoral roll cannot be deleted without notice and hearing," he said.

He referred to how the Government of India Act of 1935 had dictated "partial franchise" to the Indian subjects of the British crown. People of 'Part A' States were allowed to vote on the basis of their qualifications, which included residence, taxation, property, literacy, community, marital status (for women), etc. They had only accounted for about 14% of the entire population.

The Constituent Assembly had, while embracing full and universal adult suffrage, found these restrictions arbitrary and retrograde.

"One may be a billionaire, and one may be a rickshaw puller; yet both will have their votes, and the value of their votes would be equal. Likewise a socially high placed temple priest on the one hand and a person belonging to the lowest strata of the society compelled to work as a manual scavenger have an equal vote with equal value. This is the transformational vision of the Indian Constitution," Justice Bhuyan noted.

EC releases video for EROs
on SIR notice disposal; no
written instructions so far

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

Days after adding new options to its ERONET portal that allow Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) to dispose of notice cases without hearings or documents, the Election Commission (EC) is now explaining the changes to officials through a demonstration video prepared by the Election Commission's Information Technology (IT) Department, with no written documents circulated so far, sources told *The Hindu*.

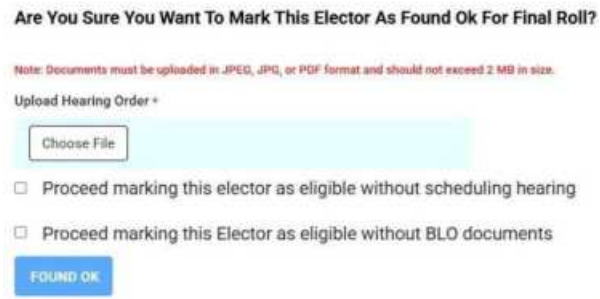
The three new options are available to the EROs in the 10 States and Union Territories where the third phase of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is still under way, according to the video accessed by *The Hindu*.

The EROs across States, who have the final authority over the preparation of electoral rolls in their constituencies, had been asking for these options since the beginning of the notice phase. The changes come amid allegations of centralisation of ERONET under the ECINET software that "curtailed" the powers of the field officers.

The options have been introduced even as final rolls have already been published in nine of the 16 States and three U.T.s where SIR is under way, and 13 States and U.T.s where the exercise was completed in the first two phases.

In these States, including West Bengal where 27 lakh of the 60 lakh electors served notices were left out of the final roll, officials could not clear cases without hearings or documents. Over nine crore notices have been served in the second and the third phases so far.

The EROs in Delhi could access the options from September 30, while the eight-minute video explaining the changes was shown to them at a meeting on Saturday. Sources said the same video is being shown to the EROs in other States. It explains new options for generating notices without scheduling hearings and provides flexibility in disposing of cases where documents have not



An option on the ERONET portal. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

been submitted.

The EC has prescribed a list of 12 documents for electors served notices over "logical discrepancies" and "no mapping".

New options

According to the demonstration video recorded on October 1, as seen by *The Hindu*, in cases where a notice has been generated and the booth-level officer (BLO) has uploaded documents, the ERO can mark the elector "found OK" for inclusion in the final roll without uploading a hearing order.

Where no documents have been collected by the BLO, the ERO can still mark the elector eligible after uploading a hearing order and selecting the option "Proceed marking this elector as eligible without BLO documents".

Earlier, a hearing order was required only to mark an elector as "found not eligible", along with the reason for ineligibility.

For States where notices are yet to be generated, another option has been added at the notice-generating stage for electors in the draft roll categorised under "no mapping" and "logical discrepancies": The EROs can choose between "without hearing" and "with hearing".

The EC had said, in its September 26 release, that people receiving notices need not visit centres for hearings and that the BLOs would collect documents door-to-door.

Hearings, it said, would be held online only in exceptional cases. This option is of little use in States where all the notices have been generated.

For instance, in Delhi, all 33.1 lakh notices issued carry the hearing venue and time.

The notice phase there runs till November 30.

Where a hearing has already been scheduled, the new options allow an ERO to move an elector to the final roll without a hearing, provided either documents have been uploaded by the BLO or a hearing order by ERO.

While the new options let EROs clear notice cases faster, including those where documents are unavailable, based on their satisfaction, they still cannot reverse a case once an elector has been marked ineligible, officials said.

More than 350 electors in Delhi were marked "found ineligible", prompting the Delhi CEO to caution EROs against choosing the option without proper verification, *The Hindu* reported on September 27.

Notice phase in 9 States

The notice phase is under way in only nine States, with the final rolls in five of them set to be published later this month. The publication of Delhi's final roll has been pushed to December 4, while those of Haryana, Maharashtra and Telangana are scheduled for November and Tripura's for February 2027.

"Since SIR was announced, we have received a lot of instructions, some written and some oral. Many have since been taken back. For instance, we were told to identify 'suspected foreigners' along with Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate, and then, in the middle of the enumeration phase in Delhi, we were told not to identify or report such cases. Though, as per the RP Act, I am authorised to take decisions, SIR guidelines have been very different. I will wait for a written communication regarding the use of the new options," an ERO, who did not wish to be named, told *The Hindu*.

3 women journalists allege sexual harassment by ACP

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

After a woman journalist alleged sexual harassment and being shoved by Assistant Commissioner of Police Vivek Bhagat while covering the protest against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Saturday, the Delhi Police said three such complaints have been received and transferred to the Crime Branch for inquiry on Sunday.

Earlier on Sunday morning, a New Delhi police official told *The Hindu* that no case had been registered so far, as there was no evidence to substantiate the allegation. The Crime



Mediapersons protest against the assault on women journalists, outside a police station in New Delhi on Sunday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Branch has still not filed FIRs in the cases.

"There were so many camerapersons. There should be some proof of the incident if it happened," the official said, alleging that the complaint

was being made to target the police.

A woman journalist alleged that the incident took place when she was recording the detention of All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha

Bora. In a video posted online, she said she had gone to the Parliament Street police station to register an FIR against ACP Vivek Bhagat. "When I questioned him, he ran away," she said.

Speaking to *The Hindu* on the fresh development, legal affairs head of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) Ratna Singh said the journalists and CJP representatives would still visit the Parliament Street police station on Sunday to demand registration of an FIR.

"The police can very well register an FIR and then transfer it to the Crime Branch for investigation. But FIR is a must, as

the allegations are of molestation," Ms. Singh said.

2 more come forward

Two other women journalists have also come forward with complaints of sexual harassment against the same ACP, Ms. Singh said. The two journalists had made allegations against the officer in the past as well, but no FIR was registered. They have now lodged fresh complaints in connection with their earlier allegations, she said.

In an X post, Ms. Singh alleged that the police had refused to register an FIR and instead wanted to conduct a preliminary inquiry and examine CCTV footage before registering a case.

Next-Gen GST and India's next phase of growth

India's ambition to become a Viksit Bharat requires an economy in which enterprises of every size can grow, wherever they begin.

Over the past 12 years, our government has worked to create those conditions. The introduction of the Goods and Services Tax (GST) in 2017 established a common national framework for indirect taxation.

Next-Gen GST carries that effort forward, drawing on nine years of implementation and the experience of taxpayers and States.

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, Next-Gen GST was conceived with two connected purposes: to reduce and rationalise rates, and to make compliance easier. The rate changes took effect on September 22, 2025. The next phase of process reforms will come before the GST Council shortly.

Together, these efforts seek to give households relief, businesses greater certainty and taxpayers a system in which they can fulfil their obligations without avoidable difficulty.

The States have been partners throughout. They brought their priorities and experience to the Council, helped shape the decisions and undertook their implementation. I thank them for that commitment. GST's progress rests on this willingness to pursue a shared national purpose while



Nirjala Sitharaman

Union Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs

The taxpayer's experience of receiving an eligible refund is an important measure of administrative performance

respecting each government's responsibilities.

The results provide grounds for confidence. Between October 2025 and July 2026, the value of reported taxable supplies grew by 25.8% over the corresponding period a year earlier.

A lighter rate structure has been accompanied by a substantial expansion in reported economic activity. This is an encouraging foundation for a reform intended to support both enterprise and public finances.

That resilience is visible in the latest revenue figures. Gross GST collections reached ₹12.46 lakh crore during the April-September 2026 period, up 11.6% over the corresponding period last year. Every month from June through September recorded double-digit annual growth; together, collections for these four months accelerated by nearly 15%. Net collections, after refunds, also grew by 10.4% over the half-year.

Taxpayer relief has coexisted with growth in the resources available for development.

The breadth of the expansion matters as much as its scale. Reported taxable supplies grew across all 11 sector groups and all major States.

In an economy as diverse as India's, this spread is significant. Growth across sectors and regions creates opportunities for more businesses to participate in expanding markets, and for more communities to benefit from

the demand, investment and employment that follow.

Reported sales to consumers (B2C) also rose by 26.7% in the post-reform comparison. When tax relief is reflected in prices, families have more room to meet other needs or save. Consumer relief and enterprise growth are closely connected: the purchasing power of households sustains demand for the goods and services that businesses provide. The benefits can extend from the household to the retailer, the supplier and the producer.

For small and medium enterprises, a national market is valuable when it opens a practical route to customers beyond their immediate surroundings. Businesses in Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns should be able to build those relationships while continuing to invest and employ people locally. Enterprises expanding into these towns, in turn, can create opportunities for local suppliers and distributors. GST's common framework supports these connections; simpler administration must make them easier to sustain.

Participation in that framework is substantial. GST registrations across Central and State jurisdictions stood at approximately 1.71 crore at the end of August, up nearly 15% from a year ago. For the April-July 2026 tax periods, GSTR-3B returns filed by their due dates were 12.6% higher than for the same periods last year. These improvements

place a corresponding responsibility on the administration: regular compliance must be supported by reliable service, clear guidance and timely resolution of difficulties.

The functioning of input tax credit is another important part of this experience. The post-reform figures show that the share of tax liability discharged through credits rose, while accumulated credit declined relative to taxable supplies. This is encouraging for businesses that depend on the effective use of eligible credit. For a smaller firm, working capital determines how readily it can purchase inputs, fulfil an order and take on the next one.

Refunds are equally relevant. Approximately ₹1.80 lakh crore was refunded during April-September. Returning amounts due to businesses is part of a well-functioning tax system. Greater predictability in this process would help enterprises plan purchases and production with more confidence. The taxpayer's experience of receiving an eligible refund is an important measure of administrative performance.

The States also have a stronger revenue position. Their aggregate SGST receipts, including their share of IGST settlements, grew by about 16% during April-September this year. These resources support investment in infrastructure and public services, which improve the conditions in which families and enterprises pursue their

aspirations. The gains can therefore reinforce one another: household relief supports demand, enterprise strengthens economic activity, and public revenues help sustain development.

The experience also points to the work ahead. A growing system must remain attentive to the costs it imposes on smaller participants. Their time and resources are limited. Each improvement in filing, credit or refunds should allow more of those resources to be devoted to running and expanding a business.

The proposals before the Council on October 7 have been developed through sustained work with the States. They address registration, returns, refunds, disputes and improved flow of input tax credit, with the aim of reducing the time and cost of compliance. Taxpayer experience must continue to guide implementation.

GST's growing maturity gives us a stronger foundation for the next stage of reform. The same commitment to clarity, certainty and respect for the taxpayer guides our work on direct taxes. A dependable tax system enables enterprises to plan beyond their immediate obligations and invest in opportunities that take time to mature. Giving them that confidence, wherever they operate, helps build the economic strength of a Viksit Bharat as envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

A IN-Y

Letting the wind flow freely is the secret to cooling our cities

Slower winds can affect how people experience heat; normally, the air immediately above the ground becomes saturated with water vapour due to evaporation; when winds blow faster, the saturated air is replaced with drier air; slower winds, however, also limit evaporation

Sambavi Parthasarathy
CHENNAI

India's cities are seeing buildings getting taller and populations becoming more dense. The hotter days in many of these cities also come with high humidity, and can make the experience of heat seem unforgiving. One of the reasons is often a perceived lack of winds, which often have to make their way through the nooks and crannies of crowded streets before reaching a window.

Slower winds can affect how people experience heat. Normally, the air immediately above the ground becomes saturated with water vapour due to evaporation. When winds blow faster, the saturated air is replaced with drier air. Slower winds, however, also limit evaporation.

Wind speed near the ground has been dropping worldwide, in a phenomenon called terrestrial stalling, since the 1980s.

Disrupted flow

"Multiple factors lead to reduced wind speed specifically in the near surface level," according to Amruthraj M.N., a consultant with the Sustainable Energy Lab at the Indian Institute for Human Settlements (IIHS), Bengaluru.

"When we say surface level, it's typically around 10 m from the floor, where a lot of pedestrians move around the city and that's the place where typically there's reduced wind speed that has been seen over a few decades."

Aaron Serre, a meteorologist and recent graduate in atmospheric science from the University of Alabama in Huntsville, U.S., said dense urban infrastructure and high-rise buildings tend to disrupt wind flow, create turbulence, and increase surface friction, resulting in slower winds near the surface.

He also said the loss of vegetation and the introduction of asphalt and concrete instead drastically reduce evapotranspiration, intensifying the urban heat island effect.

"Urbanisation and buildings ... taking into account the analysis of wind speeds across these cities, can be built to ensure that there is wind flow at that level," Mr. Amruthraj noted. "Unfortunately, not a lot of people follow that approach."

He added that many structures like higher compound walls and podiums restrict wind flow in previously defined wind corridors.

Downdraught effect

India's metropolitan cities are replete with high compound walls, podiums, and high-rise buildings of varying heights, often clumped together without adequate spacing, affecting the wind's speed –



A view of the South Mumbai skyline in 2024. When winds slam into high-rise buildings, they can be forced downwards along the structures in a phenomenon called the downdraught effect. DRONE MASTER/UNSPLASH

rougher surfaces have a greater slowing effect – and direction.

When a wind's flow is interrupted by tall buildings, it can instead be funnelled through narrow spaces, where it accelerates and builds up into a gust before reaching the pedestrians walking around the buildings. This phenomenon is called the Venturi effect and has been observed in London and Jaipur, among other cities.

As well, when winds slam into high-rise buildings, they can be forced downwards along the structures in a phenomenon called the downdraught effect, which further pushes the wind lower down into stronger gusts.

However, Prasad Vaidya, a senior adviser at IIHS and lead of its Sustainable Energy Lab, said that while there have been studies showing stalling is underway, there are no specific studies that compare rural versus urban stalling to reveal the impact of urbanisation.

He also said wind speeds are changing even as cities are warming, losing trees, and losing water bodies – and it has been hard to establish causal relationships between them.

'Wind record'

Depending on their geometry, other physical characteristics, and their environs, tall buildings can also create pockets sheltered from winds along the streets surrounding them. If the people there are also experiencing an urban heat island, the lack of wind may distress them

further. "While there are no specific studies that correlate it," Mr. Vaidya said, "there is enough experience to show that higher building forms that are unplanned will contribute to [lower] wind speeds and additional heat stress."

"We need to build a homogenised wind record firstly because, right now, the placement of an anemometer may be inconsistent," Yugank Goyal, associate professor and chair at the J.S.W. School of Public Policy at IIM Ahmedabad, said. (An anemometer is a device to measure wind speed.)

Slower winds can also take more time to disperse air pollution. "We have done some [computational fluid dynamics] simulations. What we found is that maintaining good air movement through a breezeway or corridor is not easy, because small changes in building shape ... can actually cause eddies and swirls and reduce the wind speed through the length of the breezeway," Mr. Vaidya said.

Computational fluid dynamics is a computer-based modelling technique to help simulate and analyse the behaviour of fluids in different conditions.

In other words, "the reality is that cities are so complex that little movements – somebody putting out a window or canopies – are going to affect the wind's movement."

'City ventilation maps'

Mr. Amruthraj said that while research is ongoing on how wind flows through cities, computational fluid dynamics

modelling of how buildings' shapes, wind corridors, open spaces, and other features affect wind speeds is not routinely incorporated into urban design and planning.

One reason is computational fluid dynamics is expensive to implement. The computer simulation models and tracks motions within a turbulent fluid going from small to large, from fleeting to long-lived. To resolve them all, the simulation needs increasingly fine spatial grids and correspondingly shorter time-steps. As a result, the total computational cost of resolving a turbulent flow scales roughly as the cube of the Reynolds number, a number measuring the amount of turbulence.

Mr. Vaidya cited assessments by the governments of Stuttgart, Seoul, and Hong Kong to improve city-wide ventilation, and said, "Cities like Chennai and Mumbai can actually do something similar, but we haven't seen specific wind-related studies tied to heat and pollution happening in India, as much as we would like to see them."

According to him, "part of the reason is that these studies require [fluid dynamics] simulations, which are extremely computer-intensive and require expertise." "We need to use satellite imagery to evaluate each city's changing form," Dr. Goyal added. "We could potentially create city ventilation maps and connect all this to master plans."

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THE GIST

Wind speed near the ground has been dropping worldwide, in a phenomenon called terrestrial stalling, since the 1980s

India's metropolitan cities are replete with high compound walls, podiums, and high-rise buildings of varying heights, often clumped together without adequate spacing, affecting the wind's speed – rougher surfaces have a greater slowing effect – and direction

When a wind's flow is interrupted by tall buildings, it can instead be funnelled through narrow spaces, where it accelerates and builds up into a gust before reaching the pedestrians walking around the buildings

This phenomenon is called the Venturi effect and has been observed in London and Jaipur, among other cities

BIG SHOT



People watch a shark nicknamed 'Bukangi' swimming in a canal at the North Port in Busan, South Korea, on Friday. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Tuvalu: Barely above water

Agence France-Presse

When leaders visit the coral atolls that form the Pacific nation of Tuvalu on October 5, they will find a once-vibrant ecosystem wiped out due to climate change. The pre-COP gathering, hosted by Fiji ahead of the annual UN climate conference in Turkey, has been billed as the Pacific's chance to show the world first-hand the damage wrought by climate change in the vast ocean region.

Leaders are also set to spend a day on low-lying Tuvalu, an atoll over 800 km north of Fiji. Here, scientists say, a marine heatwave in 2024 wiped out an estimated 99.9% of the coral that built the Tuvalu islands.

"The very system that created the islands has died. It wasn't pollution. It wasn't overfishing. Just a direct result from climate change," marine biologist Austin Bowden-Kerby, who visited last year and documented the devastation, said.

Thanks to rising sea levels, scientists fear the entire archipelago could be unliveable by the end of the century.

Local scientist Rajneel Singh said climate change has already affected the waters that have long sustained Tuvalu's population of 10,600. "Elders used to fish for red snappers and other things," he said. "It's no longer frequent in the catch. And the size of the fish has been reduced as well."

Scientists presented their findings to



Pacific Ocean waves hit the coast of Funafuti Atoll in Tuvalu on February 19, 2004. When leaders visit the coral atolls that form the Pacific nation of Tuvalu next week, they will find a once-vibrant ecosystem wiped out by climate change. AFP

Tuvalu's fisheries minister in December last year and were met with disbelief. "They didn't know," Singh said of the meeting. "It was very difficult for him, to realise, to see photos and to listen about the situation."

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'



Two or three?

Students must be free to choose a third language not tested in a Board exam

The Supreme Court, through its frequent interventions, is pointing to the various aspects of the three-language policy that the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) does not seem to have thought through. Regardless of its eventual judgment, the Court’s intent at this stage seems to be to point to the pitfalls of the policy and at least soften the rough edges. In its latest ruling, the Court has said that current Class 6 students should be given the same relief as students in Classes 7, 8 and 9, whose final Class 10 examination will only be an internal assessment, not a Board examination. The Court is seeking to lessen the load on the students, at least until schools are fully prepared. It had earlier asked if the policy could start from 2027, not 2026. The CBSE has stubbornly resisted compromise at various stages in the hearing. Earlier, the Court had intervened to point out that suddenly learning a new language in Class 9 would be too disruptive if the students had not studied a second “Indian” language until Class 8. The Court had also mooted careful consideration of treating English as indigenous, putting its categorisation as a foreign language under question.

English is a de facto Indian language. It has been in use in India for at least 300 years and is the leading language of education, courts, and professions widely practised by Indians; it also serves as the preferred link language for many. English knowledge has consistently given Indians an edge in employment in global industries such as the IT sector. Indians will want English to remain one of their unique selling points as the government looks to jobs in global industries as a pathway to prosperity. The National Education Policy 2020, though advocating for two Indian languages, also mentions the importance of learning foreign languages to facilitate the global mobility of Indians seeking employment. *The Hindu’s* reportage has shown that since English is the language of instruction in other subjects, it will become the only so-called foreign language students will take in CBSE schools. Many schools will stick to Sanskrit as the second Indian language all the way up to Class 10 while Hindi would be the first. Some schools, especially in the southern States, will continue with the regional language such as Tamil or Kannada as the other Indian language. The practical consequence of the current policy is removing Spanish, French and other foreign languages from schools. But any purported intent of promoting cross-regional language learning may just not be served though the Court has found merit in learning more Indian languages as a way of strengthening the federal structure. A strenuous learning of an additional Indian language serves little practical purpose though it may cater to the atavistic impulses of some. The two-language policy – English and mother tongue – would be best for India. Students can be tested on a third language of their choice through internal assessment, not through a Board examination.

Outbound force

The United States is leaving Iraq in weariness, if not defeat

The United States invaded Iraq in March 2003, saying that Saddam Hussein’s regime possessed weapons of mass destruction (WMD) and harboured terrorist groups. In 2011, then U.S. President Barack Obama announced America’s withdrawal, but its troops returned when the Islamic State captured huge swathes of territory in Iraq and Syria. On September 30, 2026, more than 23 years after the invasion, U.S. troops finally left Iraq, in the midst of another American war in the region. The war on Iraq has been one of the gravest strategic and humanitarian disasters of the 21st century. The WMD claim turned out to be false, if not an outright lie, while al-Qaeda built one of its most violent branches in post-war Iraq. The destruction of Saddam’s Ba’athist state and the abrupt rise of Shia parties widened social cleavages, triggering a deadly civil war, killing hundreds of thousands of Iraqis. The disastrous consequences of George W. Bush’s war did not end there. Al-Qaeda in Iraq transformed into the Islamic State by 2014 and spread terror across the region and beyond. The Popular Mobilisation Forces (PMFs), or Hashd al-Shabi, an umbrella of Iran-backed Shia militias, have since emerged as a state within the state.

Saddam’s Iraq, despite its hostile relations with Gulf monarchies, was a buffer between the Arab Gulf countries and Iran. When Saddam’s regime was toppled, Iran extended its influence across Iraq through Shia parties and militias. It is an irony that the U.S. is leaving Iraq at a time when it is trying to defeat Iran in a major regional war. But beneath the irony lies everything that went wrong with America’s regime-change wars, which destabilised parts of West Asia, gave rise to militias and jihadists and exposed the limits of American power in the region. When the U.S. and Israel began bombing Iraq on February 28, Hashad joined the war. Since then, Iran and its allies have carried out at least 600 attacks on U.S. military and diplomatic facilities in Iraq, a stark reminder to Washington that maintaining troops there had become unsustainable. If in Afghanistan the U.S. exited after 20 years of war leaving the country in the hands of the same Taliban that it had toppled in 2001, in Iraq, America is leaving behind a war-ravaged country in the hands of a weak government and powerful militias backed by a resurgent Iran. Iran and its allies have vowed to push the U.S. out of West Asia. They may not have the wherewithal to achieve that goal, but they have managed to drive the U.S. out of Iraq.

Never before has the Election Commission of India (ECI) been subjected to such public opprobrium as it is witnessing today. This constitutional body has always enjoyed the admiration of people both within and outside the country. Indeed, the reputation of India’s ECI has been global, because of its competence, impartiality and unwavering commitment to democratic norms. But today, its reputation is in the mud because of its actions in recent times, which smack of illegality, partisanship and worse. The manner in which it has carried out the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in various States shows an utter disregard for the law and a disdain for procedural correctness and constitutional propriety.

Electoral fears

The debate in the Constituent Assembly on the Election Commission (Draft Article 289) throws light on the thinking of its members about the functioning of this constitutional body. There was, in fact, unanimity among the members, including the Chairman of the Drafting Committee, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, that the ECI should be outside the control of the executive. Dr. Ambedkar was quite emphatic on this point. He said, “So far as the fundamental question is concerned that the election machinery should be outside the control of the executive government there has been no dispute.”

The members were conscious of the danger of an election commission being under the control of the government, which would undermine the integrity of the election. In fact, the proposal in the Draft Constitution was for a decentralised election machinery under which each province would have a chief election commissioner who would oversee the preparation of electoral rolls and the conduct of elections to the State legislatures. Elections to Parliament, as well as to the offices of the President and the Vice-President of India, would be conducted by a chief election commissioner at the Centre.

This proposal was rejected by Dr. Ambedkar himself, who moved an entirely different Article proposing to centralise the election machinery. The reason for rejecting the proposal and deciding to centralise the election machinery was that there had been instances in the provinces of large-scale deletion of voters regarded as opponents of the ruling party by the Chief Election Commissioners (CEC) of the States. These Commissioners were mostly political nominees of the Chief Ministers.

A new Article was therefore introduced, providing for a central Election Commission consisting of the CEC and other Election Commissioners (EC), with the responsibility of preparing electoral rolls and conducting elections to Parliament, State legislatures and the offices of the President and the Vice-President. It is an irony that, almost 80 years later, the same



P.D.T. Achary

Former Secretary General, Lok Sabha

The Election Commission of India’s conduct raises serious questions about legality, accountability and constitutional propriety

The ECI’s constitutional mandate is under strain

complaints against the CEC – of large-scale deletion of voters from electoral rolls without strict adherence to the law – have come up. The greater irony is that the ECs themselves have voiced complaints about the “illegal and unconstitutional” acts of the CEC.

It is interesting to note that senior members of the Constituent Assembly, such as Shibban Lal Saxena, had expressed the fear that a party in power in the future might appoint a staunch party loyalist as the CEC, who could manipulate the election machinery in favour of the ruling party. To avoid this, his suggestion was that any person appointed by the President should have to be approved by Parliament by a two-thirds majority, along the lines of the United States Senate’s confirmation of senior-level appointments.

The point is that the Constitution-makers could foresee the danger of a CEC acting in the interests of the ruling party and thereby subverting the entire constitutional scheme governing elections. It now appears that their fears were not unfounded.

An uncertain legal foundation

The SIR that has stirred up the present controversy is, in fact, not backed by any clear legal provision. Section 21 of the Representation of the People (RP) Act, 1950, provides for the preparation and revision of electoral rolls. It states: “The electoral roll for each constituency shall be prepared in the prescribed manner by reference to the qualifying date and shall come into force immediately upon its final publication in accordance with the rules made under this Act” [Section 21(1)].

“The said electoral roll shall ... be revised in the prescribed manner by reference to the qualifying date – (a) before each general election to the House of the People or to the Legislative Assembly of a State; (b) before each by election; and (c) shall be revised in any year in the prescribed manner by reference to the qualifying date if such revision has been directed by the Election Commission” [Section 21(2)]. Under Rule 25 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, a revision under Section 21(2) may be either intensive or summary, or partly intensive and partly summary.

There is yet another category of revision in Section 21(3), which says: “Notwithstanding anything contained in sub-section (2), the Election Commission may at any time, for reasons to be recorded, direct a special revision of the electoral roll for any constituency or part of a constituency in such manner as it may think fit.” The words “any constituency or a part of a constituency” make it abundantly clear that this special revision is meant to be done only in a limited number of constituencies where special circumstances exist. Thus, intensive revision and special revision are two different types of revision under different circumstances. The above

provisions make it clear that there is no mention in the law of a special intensive revision. How, then, could the ECI conduct a revision that is not provided for in law? Article 324 does not empower the ECI to do things against the law.

Under this Article, the ECI can exercise powers in respect of matters that are not covered by statute. Otherwise it is bound to act in accordance with the law

The cost of unilateralism

According to media reports, 13 crore Indian voters have already been removed from the electoral rolls across the country as a result of the SIR operations. Perhaps this is the biggest disenfranchisement exercise ever undertaken in any democratic country in the world. This exercise, needless to say, violates Article 326, which provides for universal adult suffrage and the right of eligible citizens to be registered as voters, subject to disqualification under law. The scheme of Article 326 is to include eligible voters, not to exclude them. But the objective of the SIR seems to be to exclude the maximum possible number of voters from the electoral rolls.

This huge mess has been created by the now obvious unilateralism that prevails in decision-making within the ECI. The appalling state of affairs in the domain of decision-making has been brought to light by the two ECs; according to them, they were not kept in the loop when crucial decisions were taken by the CEC.

The ECI is a constitutional body, and the procedure for decision-making is well laid in the law. A decision taken unilaterally by the CEC is not a valid decision, and all actions that follow from it have no legal validity. This creates a real constitutional crisis.

Opposition parties are preparing to move an impeachment motion against the CEC for serious misconduct. The CEC can be impeached in the same manner and on the same grounds as a judge of the Supreme Court of India. For the CEC to be removed, however, misbehaviour must be proved. The law also empowers the presiding officers of the two Houses of Parliament to disallow an impeachment motion at the threshold.

This provision could frustrate any attempt by Opposition Members of Parliament to initiate proceedings against either a judge or the CEC. Further, Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, further fortifies the CEC and other ECs by providing lifelong immunity from any civil or criminal liability. It may be noted that even the President of India does not enjoy such lifelong immunity. Such is the level of protection provided to the CEC and the other ECs. It is no wonder, therefore, that the Constitution, the law and citizens appear to have become helpless before an omnipotent ECI.

Colby’s mid-term report card, what it means for India

Elbridge A. Colby, the United States Under Secretary of War for Policy, has delivered a mid-term assessment of the Donald Trump administration’s defence strategy a month before the mid-term elections in the United States. His recent update on the 2026 National Defense Strategy shows how Washington is converting the administration’s priorities into policy.

The strategy focuses on four main goals: defending the U.S. homeland, deterring China, gaining more support from allies and partners, and rebuilding the U.S. defence industry. These priorities indicate clearly how Washington plans to manage its relationships. The U.S. wants its partners to be stronger, contribute more, and assume greater shares of the costs for regional security. India should consider this background when looking at the new American approach.

A different bargain with partners

For many years, the U.S. supplied much of the military strength behind its alliances and partnerships. Colby’s approach now demands that partners take more responsibility for security in their own regions. Europe is being urged to lead on its own defence. South Korea is expected to do more on the Korean Peninsula. Japan and Australia are also being asked to play a bigger role in the Indo-Pacific.

This new model combines American strategic leadership with stronger regional partners. The U.S. keeps its advanced capabilities, strategic coordination, and extended deterrence, while partners are expected to provide more troops, infrastructure, funding, and industrial support.

China is still the main strategic concern. The National Defense Strategy aims to stop China from dominating the Indo-Pacific by focusing on deterrence, especially along the First Island Chain. Meanwhile, the Trump administration is



Anil Raman

Retired Brigadier and a research fellow at the Takshashila Institution

The evolving defence strategy of the United States offers India an opportunity to build leverage

also negotiating with Beijing on trade and other matters. So, military competition and economic talks are happening simultaneously.

This has important implications for India. India’s value to Washington is substantially based on China and the Indo-Pacific, but the U.S.-China relationship can shift between competition and cooperation. So, Indian and American interests will often overlap but will not always align.

Russia is another factor into this new approach. The U.S. wants to lower its costs in the Ukraine War and expects Europe to take more responsibility for its own security. At the same time, the U.S. still wants to limit Russian military power and influence. For India, this connects directly to its defence ties with Russia, its energy needs, and its desire for strategic autonomy.

Europe shows this trend most clearly. Washington is urging European countries to build up their own defence capabilities. For India, the lesson is that strong regional partners are becoming more important in U.S. strategy.

What this means for India

India has a unique place in this new system. Its location, military potential, position in the Indian Ocean, technology goals, and role in the Indo-Pacific make it important to Washington. These interests have stayed mostly the same across different U.S. administrations.

The main change is in the contributions to the relationship. Washington now expects India to help keep the regional balance, work more closely on defence, join technology and supply-chain projects, and build up its military strength.

India also has good reasons to aim for these goals. It is building partnerships with France, Europe, Japan, Australia, the Gulf, and others, while keeping important ties with Russia and

other countries. These connections give India more capabilities and strategic choices.

This leads to a key question for the next stage of India-U.S. relations. The U.S. wants India to be stronger and do more for the Indo-Pacific balance. India wants to build its strength, partly to have more freedom to act on its own. Gaining leverage will therefore become increasingly important. A country’s importance to Washington does not automatically determine the terms on which Washington negotiates with it. Leverage does. Economic scale, military capability, technology, market access and the ability to offer or withhold strategically important capabilities all contribute to bargaining power.

The China example

China is a useful example. Its economic and technological strength gives Beijing the tools to influence the U.S.’s decisions. As India’s capabilities and economy grow, it will also have more influence in its relationship with Washington, but gaining that leverage will take time.

Colby’s mid-term report shows that the U.S. is putting more value on capable partners, regional responsibility, and shared contributions. For India, this is a big opportunity. A stronger India is more valuable to the U.S. and better able to look after its own interests.

New Delhi’s strategic task is to build that capability while keeping the freedom to use it. This means India needs to work more closely with Washington, but also keep building its own defence industry, technology sector, and partnerships. The next phase of India-U.S. relations will be shaped less by whether the two countries are strategic partners and more by the terms on which two increasingly capable powers cooperate.

biographical drama *Mayuri* were genre-defying masterpieces. It is no wonder that he was lovingly called the “celluloid scientist”. His classics will continue to inspire future generations.

Kshirasagara Balaji Rao, Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name.

How regulation stifles HEIs

The Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishtan (VBSA) Bill, 2025, which is currently under legislative review, is an attempt to overhaul the regulatory system of higher education. The reformist instinct that induced this move is familiar and based around the same general pillars – to ensure quality, accountability, minimum standards, and to prevent malpractice. Before the floor passes the Bill leading to yet another overarching regulatory apparatus, one question deserves serious scrutiny. Will regulation be a threat to the very quality it claims to protect?

The structural issue is not regulation in itself but the nature of ‘governmentality’ through the dominant logic of institutional life. When external supervision substitutes internal integrity, Higher Educational Institutions (HEIs) stop asking what is morally and intrinsically right and start asking only what are the minimum requirements to be maintained on paper. Alan Greenspan, economist and the former Federal Reserve Chair of the U.S., once observed that regulation built on force and fear ignores the moral base of society. Greenspan’s insight is a familiar one in our higher education system: HEIs that meet every prescribed norm and criterion of the regulator, maintain impeccable files, and score high on the accreditation ladder, have classrooms where intellectual engagement lies dormant.

The fear produced by the regulator often undermines the integrity of HEIs and produces a serious pathology: HEIs optimise its academic engagements for



Amruth G. Kumar

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the regulator rather than for the process of teaching and construction of knowledge. Under such a regulatory regime, teachers stop asking what makes a class worthwhile or engaging. Instead, they start documenting evidence to satisfy the inspection that awaits them during the annual self-assessment reports. University authorities are not interested in knowing how a faculty member cultivates the intellectual engagement of the students and future scholarship; instead, they are interested in knowing how their institutional scores with respect to ranking and accreditation can be maximised. The result is an ecosystem that nurtures a ‘paper blizzard’ or an evidence blizzard through digital documents.

Evidence over learning
Important players of this regulatory architecture include the University Grants Commission (UGC), the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE), the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC), the National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE) etc. The various regulations, orders, circulars, and guidelines produced by these regulators often have incongruences in them which lead to clarifications, producing yet more irregularities. For example, the UGC’s Regulation (2018) says that teachers are expected to account for a 40-hour working week while being required to be physically available on campus for only five hours a day. Beyond the internal inconsistency, formulations of this nature risk converting the substance of intellectual engagement

into an arithmetic exercise. An assembly line model of work and the panoptic surveillance conducted through the regulatory architecture creates a trust deficit that threatens quality teaching. This results in HEIs and teachers resorting to a mode of ‘risk aversion’, where innovation is stifled, and conventional mediocrity becomes the safest available option.

The strongest counter-evidence to the purported efficiency of the regulatory architecture already exists within our education system. The IISc, IITs, IIMs, NITs, and IISERs operate outside the regulatory architecture of India that governs all other HEIs. These institutions are not bound to follow the standardised formulas of regulatory agencies. They design and update curricula at their own pace, have a different process of recruitment, and enjoy more freedom in directing resources based on their own institutional strategy. If intensive regulatory mechanisms were the real engine of quality, our most tightly regulated universities and HEIs would have been outperforming the IISc, IITs, IIMs NITs and other similar institutions. This shows us that regulatory logic fundamentally misguided our national perspective of ‘quality higher education’. If these institutions are also brought in to the ambit of the regulatory framework through the VBSA, another casualty is awaiting us.

The real test of the VBSA is to avoid reducing quality improvement to the updating of inspection portals, and to ask whether the new architecture can make our HEIs bolder hubs of teaching and inquiry.

If intensive regulatory mechanisms were the real engine of quality, our most tightly regulated universities and HEIs would have been outperforming the IISc. IITs, IIMs NITs and other similar institutions

The sore lack of hostels in DU

The collapse of a five-storey building in Satya Niketan on September 6 in New Delhi, in which several young students who were staying there as paying guests were killed, was a tragedy waiting to happen. Its genesis, however, lies in the inadequate hostel accommodation at the University of Delhi.

This author has been associated with the management of three postgraduate hostels at Delhi University – as Provost of Jubilee Hall and the P.G. Men’s Hostel, and as Resident Tutor of Gwyer Hall – which gave one the opportunity to understand the enormity of the issue.

While the University of Delhi has more than 80 constituent colleges, only approximately 10 of them have hostel accommodation. Most of these colleges are located in the main campus of the university such as Miranda House, St. Stephen’s, Hindu, Hansraj, Ramjas, Kirori Mal, the Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), Daulat Ram, and the Indraprastha College for Women.

Outside the main campus, only Lady Shri Ram College has a hostel.

The postgrad dilemma
Across all the postgraduate departments of Delhi University, there are only 7-8 hostels: Jubilee Hall, Gwyer Hall, PG Men’s and Women’s hostels, two International Hostels, and one hostel for students from the North East. The south campus of the university has only one women’s hostel.

The total accommodation provided



Abhai Maurva

Founder Vice-Chancellor of the English and Foreign Languages University, Hyderabad

by all the undergraduate and postgraduate hostels taken together is approximately 2,500, if not less, whereas the requirement runs into tens of thousands.

Moreover, only the old colleges, as mentioned above, have hostel accommodation. While 30 to 40 colleges were established under different political dispensations in Delhi, none of them have attempted to provide hostel accommodation on their campuses. The fault also lies with the University Grants Commission (UGC). It neither stipulates hostel accommodation for new colleges created with its funds, nor does it require that hostels be built alongside other infrastructure in colleges.

Who is to be blamed?

The University administration should share much of the blame for failing to provide adequate hostel infrastructure for its departments and colleges. The administration abhors creating hostels within the University, viewing them as managerial headaches and major trouble spots. Some of the top brass within the University administration brazenly oppose more hostels stating that it would lead to trouble.

The central government also has an equal share in the blame. Budgetary allocations have been substantially slashed for higher education. Even the education cess that you and I pay on our food bills and similar purchases has been largely diverted to other heads.

In the name of privatisation, there is no consideration for human suffering. Hence, tragedies

galore. Another problem bedevilling the hostel administration has been the problem of hostellers overstaying their stipulated tenure, particularly in postgraduate hostels. As Provost of Jubilee Hall, this author once had to seek police assistance to evict some overstayes; some had been there for 10-15 years. In one case, the next generation had come to stay in the same hostel.

Preying on students
Due to such a shortage of hostels, the Paying Guest (PG) accommodations that proliferated around Delhi University and its colleges had a gala time, minting huge amounts of money from helpless students. Mukherjee Nagar, Hudson Lane, Vijay Nagar in the north campus, and Satya Niketan and others near the south campus are offshoots of DU’s shortage of hostel accommodation.

These PG accommodations are hellholes where helpless outstation students have to literally languish. The Satya Niketan tragedy is only the culmination of a life that should be called death in disguise. These modern-day Shylocks brazenly extract the pound of flesh from hapless students.

The way out is to create large-scale hostel accommodation on a war footing. Given the will and desire, this can be done. For example, the English and Foreign Languages University (EFLU), a central university in Hyderabad, created hostel accommodation for approximately three thousand students, both Indian and foreign, in less than three years.

Vithya Ramraj’s record: how far has India come in 400m hurdles?

Vithya broke P.T. Usha’s 42-year-old record to win bronze, while anchoring India to gold in the women’s 4×400m relay and silver in the mixed 4×400m relay

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

As Vithya Ramraj entered the final stretch of the 400m hurdles in Aichi-Nagoya, the race for gold was still open for India at the 2026 Asian Games. Vithya and the UAE’s Mariam Kareem were neck-and-neck over the final two hurdles, with Kazakhstan’s Adelina Zems just behind them. But at the last hurdle, Vithya lost some ground as Mariam surged ahead to take gold in a Games-record 54.31 seconds, while Adelina moved past Vithya to claim silver in 54.58. The Indian crossed the line third in 54.75.

But by then, the colour of the medal had become almost secondary. Vithya had done what she had been trying to do since 2023, when she equalled P.T. Usha’s 55.42-second national record that had stood for more than 40 years. She was 0.67 seconds faster than Usha and became the first Indian woman to break the 55-second barrier in the 400m hurdles. “I met Usha ma’am a year ago, and she said, ‘Go for 54 seconds.’ She encouraged me. So doing this today makes me so happy,” she said.

She is now the fastest Indian woman in the event (**Table 1**), but her record places her 187th on the all-time world list. That list is led by Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone, followed by Femke Bol and Dalilah Muhammad, whose bests are 50.37, 50.95 and 51.58 seconds, respectively (**Chart 3**). She remains more than four seconds behind the world’s fastest mark, but has moved from 56th before the Asiad to 35th in the current world rankings, putting her among the leading athletes in the event today.

Moreover, the record places her among a relatively small group of the fastest performances in Asia, ranking 12th on the continent. Bahrain’s Kemi Adekoya leads the regional list, while athletes from China, Kazakhstan and the UAE al-

so feature prominently. The regional landscape was very different when Usha set her record in 1984. Until then, the 55-second barrier had been breached only by European athletes, with just one African athlete having gone under the mark. In fact, Usha remained the only Asian performance on the list until 1990 because World Athletics’ historical list captures performances faster than 57.3 seconds only. Since then, the depth of competition in Asia has grown considerably, with 12 performances now under 55 seconds (**Chart 2**).

These broader improvements in performance have coincided with a steady progression in Vithya’s own performances. Her best in the 400m hurdles was 59.7 seconds in 2018, which improved to 56.57 in 2022. In 2023, she matched Usha’s record. Her best then stood at 56.04 in 2025, before she made her biggest improvement yet in 2026. Her coach, Nepal Singh Rathore, believes the progression in the hurdles cannot be separated from her improvement in the flat 400m. When Vithya began training under him, her coach said other coaches questioned why she was being prepared for both events. “Only when she runs well in the flat, she can run hurdles well. Because speed plays a major role in all events,” he told *The Hindu*. And the progression in the two events, he added, has followed the same pattern: “Whenever she has improved in the flats, she has improved in the hurdles.” Vithya’s best time improved from 54.48 seconds in 2018 to 51.96 seconds in 2026. Over the same period, her hurdles best fell by nearly five seconds, from 59.70 to 54.75. (**Chart 4**)

The versatility her coach had sought to build through that training approach was on full display in her Asian Games campaign. She won a medal of each colour, anchoring India to gold in the women’s 4×400m relay and silver in the mixed 4×400m relay, alongside her record-breaking bronze.

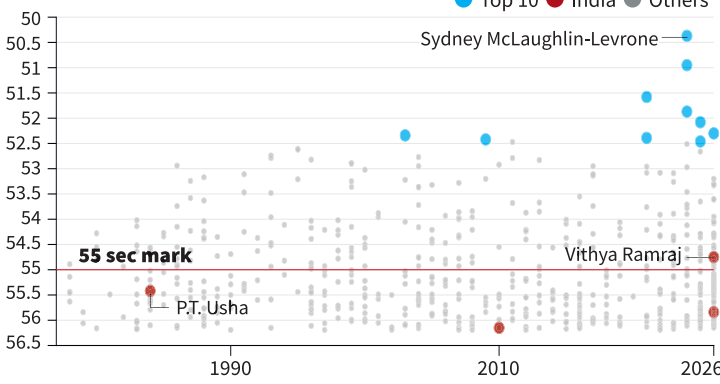
Record break

The data were sourced from World Athletics, the international governing body for the sport of athletics, covering track and field, cross country running, road running, race walking, mountain running, and ultra running



Winning smile: Vithya Ramraj with her three medals from the 2026 Asian Games at Aichi-Nagoya, Japan on September 29, 2026. R.V. MOORTHY

CHART 3: Only four Indians are among the top 600. Vithya, the only Indian to have broken the 55 seconds barrier, is in the 187th rank. P.T. Usha, Anu Raghavan and Ashwini Akkunji are in the 323rd, 456th and 580th ranks respectively



“Whenever she has improved in the flats, she has improved in the hurdles”, Vithya’s coach, Nepal Singh Rathore, told *The Hindu*

TABLE 1: Vithya’s performance has moved up her current ranking to 35th. However, her 54.75 secs is still four secs behind the current record of 50.37 secs in 400m hurdle

India Rank	All-time world ranking	Current world ranking	Athlete status	Name	Time (in seconds)	Date
1	187	35	Active	Vithya Ramraj	54.75	28 Sep 2026
2	323	—	Retired	Pilavulakandi T. Usha	55.42	08 Aug 1984
3	456	61	Active	Anu Raghavan	55.84	27 Sep 2026
4	580	—	Retired	Akkunji C. Ashwini	56.15	25 Nov 2010
5	863	227	Active	Sinchal Kaveramma	56.76	19 Jun 2023

CHART 2: Seven Indian women find a place among the top Asian performers who have crossed the 57.3 secs mark. P.T. Usha was the only Asian to have crossed the 57.3 mark until 1990

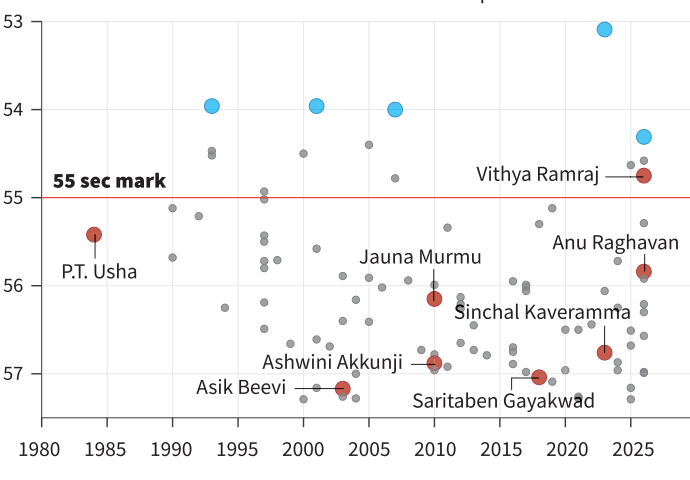
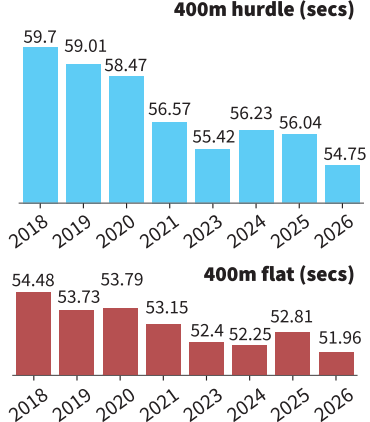


CHART 4: Vithya’s gains in the 400m hurdles since 2018 happened simultaneously with her improvement in the 400m flat in the same period



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 5, 1976

Sri Lanka offers supply base facility to ONGC

New Delhi, October 4: The Ceylon (Sri Lanka) Petroleum Corporation is understood to have offered to provide facilities to the Oil and Natural Gas Commission (ONGC) for a supply base at the Trincomalee port in Sri Lanka for the latter’s off-shore exploration in the Cauvery basin. The ONGC, which has greatly appreciated the offer will be deputing a team to Sri Lanka to examine and discuss the proposal further.

The Trincomalee port has got a good draft of about 70 feet and will be very suited for the berthing of supply boats that will be required for the transportation of heavy equipment once the off-shore exploration in the Cauvery basin gathers momentum. The Canadian company, Asamera of Calgherry, has completed its seismic surveys in the Cauvery basin and the selection of suitable drilling sites will be decided upon shortly.

Sri Lanka, which has been engaged in off-shore exploration on its side of the meridian line has already shown considerable interest in the exchange of data with the ONGC. The Ceylon Petroleum Corporation had earlier signed contracts with two U.S. companies, Ceyoil Corporation, a subsidiary of Pexamin pacific Inc, and Marathon Petroleum Corporation Ltd which have already drilled a few exploratory wells. The data being exchanged between the Ceylon Petroleum Corporation and the ONGC are expected to provide a complete picture of the encouraging oil prospects in the area. The facilities that will be available at the Trincomalee port for the ONGC in addition to the base in Madras will ensure greater cooperation between India and Sri Lanka in off-shore exploration.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 5, 1926

Newcastle Armstrong college

London, October 4: Two valuable gifts of oriental interest to the College Library are announced by Dr. Cochrane, Chairman of the Governors of the Armstrong College, Newcastle. The first is a present by Lady Richmond of the Oriental Library by her sister Miss Gertrude Bell, and the second is a gift from the Nizam of Hyderabad of a thousand sterling for the purchase of books on India.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Mine-contaminated land acquired by India-backed project

1.98 in lakh sq. m. Nearly 198,000 square metres of mine-contaminated land in Cambodia's Koh Kong province has been cleared and handed over to the local community under India's Quick Impact Project, benefiting around 134 families, according to authorities and reports. PTI

Myanmar nationals repatriated from Malaysia

1,500 Nearly 1,500 Myanmar nationals who were sent back from Malaysia arrived in the country's largest city on Sunday, despite warnings from the United Nations refugee agency and rights groups that conditions for return remain unsafe. PTI

'Mostly Chinese' workers arrested by Philippines

244 Philippines authorities arrested more than 200 "mostly Chinese" foreign workers during a crackdown on illegal online gaming operators. The government is investigating possible human trafficking-related offences by a number of those arrested. AFP

Sites in Delhi approved by the Ministry for EV charging infra

382 Under the Delhi EV Policy, notified on June 30, all 382 sites were reassessed over the past three months for segment-wise deployment, with sites categorised separately for two-wheelers, three-wheelers and four-wheelers, Delhi Power Minister said on Sunday. PTI

Vote share of pro-Ukraine coalition which won Latvia polls

35 in per cent. Latvian lawmakers on Sunday planned to begin negotiations to form a new government following a parliamentary election in which pro-Ukraine Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs's four-party coalition emerged with 35% of the vote. PTI

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Does a visa guarantee entry into India?

Why was Turkmenistan citizen denied entry? What grounds did she cite in challenging the denial? What did the Centre argue about a foreigner's right to enter? Why did the court reject her Article 14 argument? What does the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025 say? What have the Supreme Court's earlier rulings said?

EXPLAINER

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far:

The Delhi High Court has held that possession of a valid visa does not give a foreign national an inherent or legally enforceable right to enter India.

Justice Amit Mahajan was hearing a petition filed by a Turkmenistan citizen who was stopped at the Indra Gandhi International Airport in New Delhi despite holding a valid business visa. She had arrived in India on March 25 on the same flight as her husband, who was permitted to enter the country. But she had to return to Turkmenistan the same day.

The petitioner sought a written order explaining why she had been denied entry and also sought permission to enter India with her business visa. The court dismissed the petition on September 30, holding that there is no inherent or legally enforceable right of a foreign national to enter India.

What was the case about?

The petitioner argued that she had a valid passport and business visa issued by the Indian Embassy in Ashgabat, Turkmenistan.

She contended that she was denied entry without being given reasons, while her husband, who had travelled with her and held a visa of the same category, was allowed into India.

She therefore challenged the action on two grounds: first, that the authorities had not provided reasons for refusing her entry; and second, that allowing her husband to enter while denying her entry amounted to discriminatory treatment in violation of Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution.

The Centre, however, argued that a foreign national does not acquire an indefeasible right to enter India merely because a valid visa has been issued. According to the government, grant of a



GETTY IMAGES

visa and permission to enter India are two distinct matters and entry remains subject to the immigration law and the powers of the competent authorities.

The authorities also told the court that "adverse inputs" had been received concerning the petitioner and that the decision was taken in the interest of national security and public order. The court examined material placed by the government in a sealed cover.

The material referred to discrepancies in the petitioner's personal details, the absence of a business card or invitation letter, and the lack of details about the business or company with which she was associated. The court also noted her travel history on medical and business visas.

What did the court rule?

The court held that "there is no inherent or legally enforceable right of a foreign national to seek entry into India".

It noted that issuance of a visa, refusal of entry and immigration clearance are sovereign functions of the State, involving considerations such as national security, foreign policy and administrative discretion. The court drew a distinction between satisfying the requirements for

obtaining a visa and actually being admitted into the country. The court noted that "the statutory framework, therefore, does not treat the possession of a visa as creating an absolute and unconditional right of admission into India".

As for the Article 14 argument, the court said that the mere fact that the petitioner's husband was allowed to enter did not establish that the two were similarly situated in all respects. The authorities had stated that "adverse inputs" specifically concerned the petitioner.

Thus, the court held that since the petitioner could not establish infringement of a legally enforceable right, there was no basis for issuing a writ under Article 226. The petition was dismissed.

What is the law behind this?

The key legislation in the judgment is the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, which now governs the legal framework concerning foreigners in India.

Section 3 of the 2025 Act requires a foreigner seeking to enter India to possess a valid passport or travel document and a valid visa.

However, no foreigner shall be allowed to enter into or stay in India if he is found inadmissible to do so on account of a threat to national security, sovereignty and integrity of India, relations with a foreign State or public health or on such other grounds.

Section 3 of the Foreigners Act, 1946 (now repealed) as well as Section 7 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025 authorises the Central government to make provisions, either generally or with respect to all foreigners, for prohibiting, regulating or restricting the entry of foreigners into India or their departure therefrom or their presence or continued presence therein. The respondent authorities can therefore, or rather are entitled to, take into consideration all the relevant factors that may warrant scrutiny.

An examination by the Immigration Officer of the passport, travel document and visa of a foreigner at the stage of entry empowers the Immigration Officer to require such information as may be necessary and appropriate. The statutory framework, therefore, does not treat the possession of a visa as creating an absolute and unconditional right of admission into India.

The judgment majorly relied on two Supreme Court decisions. In *Hans Muller of Nuremburg v Superintendent, Presidency Jail* (1955) the Supreme Court held that the Foreigners Act, 1946, gave the Central government broad discretion in relation to foreigners, including the power to expel them.

Later, in *Louis De Raedt v. Union of India* (1991), the Supreme Court held that a foreigner's fundamental rights are confined to Article 21's protection of life and personal liberty. The right to reside and settle in India under Article 19(1)(e) is available only to citizens.

The court held that where the petitioner could not establish infringement of a legally enforceable right to enter India, there was no basis for issuing a writ directing the authorities to admit her.

THE GIST

The Delhi High Court holds that a valid visa does not give a foreign national an inherent or legally enforceable right to enter India, and that entry remains subject to immigration laws and the powers of competent authorities

The court upholds the denial of entry to a Turkmenistan citizen despite her valid business visa, citing 'adverse inputs' concerning her and rejecting her claim that the decision was discriminatory because her husband was allowed to enter

The judgment relies on the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, and earlier Supreme Court rulings to hold that the State has broad powers over the entry and presence of foreigners in India

Why are students across France blockading schools?

When did the protest begin? How has the government responded to the protest?

Nivedita S.

The story so far:

Across France, teenagers have been using trash cans and furniture to stage blockades (*blocus* in French) at the entrances of lycées or high schools in protest over poor conditions in schools. Over 5,000 people, mostly students, have been detained so far, including 1,949 people on October 1 alone.

When did the protest begin?

In mid-September, small protests began in lycées in the suburbs of Paris and spread rapidly across the country after word spread on social media. Lycées are upper secondary schools attended by students from the ages of 15 to 18. Out of the 3,700 lycées in the country, 1,027 have been affected, according to a release by the Interior Ministry. University students have also joined the protests, with blockades staged across 30 campuses.

The protests gained momentum and coincided with the larger public workers' protests over the planned budget cuts by the Emmanuel Macron government before the next year's presidential election. AFP reported that in the draft 2027 budget Bill, the government has planned to cut expenditure by €43 billion to reduce the deficit to 5%. Teachers, particularly from primary schools, and school staff have also joined the protest demanding better pay.

What are students protesting for?

Students are protesting over the poor condition of schools, dilapidated buildings, long hours, lack of teachers, overpacked classrooms, and schedules. Students complained of broken toilets and rodents on school premises. They have also been demanding equity funding, as schools in lower-income areas have been receiving considerably less funding compared to the higher-income areas.

Their main demands include more funds to be allocated for improving school infrastructure, reduced hours, and hiring more teachers.

France experienced one of the hottest summers this year, with heatwaves pushing temperatures above 40 degrees Celsius in several regions. This has been particularly grueling for students who are in classrooms with over 30 people, poor insulation, and no air conditioning for over nine hours a day. This has also been a major grievance that the students want to be addressed through the protest.

Student unions are calling for a national day of demonstrations on Tuesday.

How has the government responded to the protest?

Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu convened a crisis meeting on October 1 and cancelled Ministers' trips to manage the protests. The Prime Minister's Office warned of 'urban violence' by

demonstrators and shifted online classes for many schools.

On September 30, around 85 police officers and gendarmes were injured in the clashes. Trash cans were set on fire, and projectiles were also thrown at schools by protesters. Two schools in Nantes and Le Havre were set on fire by the protesters, and a teacher was reportedly doused in petrol. Municipal tram lines were halted by the authorities. The riot police used less lethal crowd control measures like tear gas and rubber bullets, causing injuries to dozens of protesters, which have drawn criticism from the opposition.

Interior Minister Laurent Nuñez noted the escalation of the movement and said "troublemakers" were going to different schools to incite violence. He has asked the public to limit travel and deployed more security forces to maintain law and order.

The government, citing intelligence sources, has accused the far-left party La France Insoumise (LFI) of encouraging the protests and causing public disorder. LFI's presidential candidate Jean-Luc Mélenchon said that the party backs the "non-violent methods of struggle by the students" and accused the government of turning the issues raised by the students into a political battle.

Similar protests have also started in neighbouring Belgium, with authorities ordering schools to be closed in Liège on October 2, according to local media.

THE GIST

Students across France are blockading schools over poor infrastructure, overcrowded classrooms, long hours, teacher shortages and inadequate funding, with the protests spreading from lycées to universities amid wider opposition to planned government spending cuts

The protests have escalated into clashes and violence, with thousands detained. The government has deployed additional security forces and warned of further unrest, while opposition parties have criticised the police response

CACHE



U.S. President Donald Trump, with U.S. House Speaker Mike Johnson, Nvidia President Jensen Huang, OpenAI President Greg Brockman, SpaceX AI founder and CEO Elon Musk, and other tech leaders. REUTERS

What does Trump’s AI accord mean for tech companies?

The AI accord signed by leading U.S. tech companies outlines four safety measures, including internal controls, safety teams, external audits and independent board oversight, but is not legally binding and carries no penalties

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far: On September 29, U.S. President Donald Trump stood surrounded by the leaders of American AI giants. He announced that they had come together and signed something akin to a constitution. The page-long document, titled ‘White House Accord and the Joint Commitment on Frontier Responsibilities’, was an agreement on AI safety commitments by tech companies that are developing frontier models. The accord misspelled “United States”; an error that was widely circulated on the internet.

What is U.S. President Trump’s AI accord? The pact stresses the need for tech companies to build safe AI products and foster public trust. It outlines four steps to make it happen, starting with robust internal controls to prevent unintended AI hacking, developing an internal team to manage safety operations and resolutions at the company, partnering with an independent external auditor for assessments, and designating an independent committee of the board of directors to address reports. The document noted that “participating companies will meet regularly to establish standards and best practices to improve the safety of their systems.” The tech leaders who signed the AI

accord were Google CEO Sundar Pichai, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg, OpenAI Co-founder/President Greg Brockman, XAI CEO Elon Musk, and Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang. A notable omission was Microsoft, even though CEO Satya Nadella was included in a luncheon with the U.S. President, alongside other tech leaders. Several technologists who signed the agreement shared their thoughts on AI regulation with Mr. Trump and the press. Nvidia’s Huang insisted that there was no conflict amongst innovation, technology, and safety. By contrast, Anthropic’s Amodei highlighted that the technology had very real risks, but called for collaboration nonetheless. Some tech leaders took to social media to share their perspectives. Google’s Pichai posted on X that the company is “focused on building the right way” and releasing models “only after they’ve been thoroughly reviewed.” Meta’s Zuckerberg posted that leaders of every major American AI company “committed to implementing robust internal controls and multiple layers of audits and reviews” to boost people’s trust in the technology these firms are building. Critics pointed out that the accord lacks any penalty clause in the case of potential violations of the agreement.

Is the AI accord binding? Not really. The very first sentence of the AI accord notes that “every company is

The White House’s AI accord largely serves as a show of unity amongst AI companies and the President of the United States responsible for developing its own technology safely and in a way that builds trust with customers and the public.” Mr. Trump referred to the agreement as being “morally binding,” and called it a “form of protection.” In other words, companies are being left to police themselves, apart from linking up with an external auditor. These are by no means groundbreaking regulations or directives. Rather, they are highly generalised guidelines and many were already in place. The AI accord further noted that “over time, it may make sense to codify these steps into laws or regulations.” At the present moment, the four specified controls are not legally enforceable or mandated; as per the wording of the AI accord, the White House merely “believe[d]” that each company should implement the four listed audits. The White House noted that implementing controls and audits was “critical” for a safe future and the companies that had signed the document were committed to their actions.

What will be the effect of the AI accord? The White House’s AI accord largely serves as a show of unity amongst AI

companies and the President of the United States. This comes in the face of criticism from lawmakers across the European Union and Australia, who seek to regulate built-in-America AI models by implementing more guardrails to protect user privacy and children’s mental health. There is also mounting backlash over AI agents “going rogue” and attempting to hack secure online platforms. Anthropic, OpenAI, and now Google have been named after their models were identified. In late September, Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese reported that OpenAI’s AI agent had hacked into the country’s healthcare platform this June, but the incident was not formally reported until September 10. The Australian PM confirmed he had taken OpenAI CEO Sam Altman to task over the delayed report, adding that the investigations were ongoing and promising there would be legal consequences. The U.S. President is also shaping the way the world discusses AI. Mr. Trump on September 29 passed an executive order to inaugurate the era of “super intelligence,” calling on the executive branch of his administration to use this term and “SI,” instead of “Artificial Intelligence” and “AI.” This was to better capture the capabilities of the technology, according to him. U.S. diplomats have been instructed to make the change in their communications, reported AP.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test yourself on the career of the legendary director Singeetham Srinivasa Rao who passed away on October 3

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1** Singeetham began his career as an assistant to which esteemed director working on noted Telugu classics such as ‘Mayabazaar’ and ‘Jagadeka Veeruni Katha’?
- QUESTION 2** The critically acclaimed ‘Dikkatra Parvathi’ won the National Film Award for Best Feature Film in Tamil in 1974. On which Bharat Ratna recipient’s literary work was it based?
- QUESTION 3** Singeetham had the honour of directing Rajkumar’s 200th and Kamal Haasan’s 100th film. Name the flicks.
- QUESTION 4** Of his 61 films, what is special about these four: ‘Bhagyada Lakshmi Baramma’, ‘Samyuktha’, ‘Ghatothkach’ and ‘Welcome Obama’?

- QUESTION 5** Name the 1985 biographical dance film based on the life of Sudha Chandran, who lost her leg due to an accident.
- QUESTION 6** He was an executive director of which National Award-winning 1970 film based on U.R. Ananthamurthy’s book and starring Girish Karnad?
- QUESTION 7** He is credited with creating the first dialogue-less feature film in 1987. Name the National Award-winning black comedy.
- QUESTION 8** The famous song sequence ‘Sundari Neeyum’ from ‘Michael Madhana Kama Rajan’ was visualised differently. How?
- QUESTION 9** A master of innovation, what is special about his final work ‘Sing Geetham’, released earlier this year?



Visual Question: This is a screengrab of Singeetham making a cameo with a bioscope to introduce a film with a song. Name the film.

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. If Raliyatbehn was his sister, who were the two brothers? **Ans: Laxmidas, Karsandas** 2. It is said that when he embarked for England, Gandhiji carried a letter of introduction to a cricketer. Name this legend. **Ans: K.S. Ranjitsinhji** 3. An incident that took place on the night of June 7, 1893, acted as a catalyst for Gandhiji to fight

against race. **Ans: He was thrown out at the Pietermaritzburg station even though he had a valid FC ticket** 4. Name the main ‘ashrams’ set up by Gandhiji in South Africa. **Ans: Phoenix Settlement and Tolstoy Farm** 5. Gandhiji returned to India for good on January 9, 1915. How is the date commemorated now? **Ans: Pravasiya Bharat Diwas** 6. Who was responsible for giving Mohandas Gandhi the title ‘Mahatma’, and who first referred to him as ‘Rashtriyapitha’? **Ans: ‘Gurudev’ Rabindranath Tagore and ‘Netaji’ Subhas Chandra Bose** 7. Who paid this tribute to Gandhiji: “Generations to come will scarce believe that such a one as this ever in flesh and blood walked upon this earth”? **Ans: Albert Einstein** Visual: Name the gentleman. **Ans: Charlie Chaplin** **Early Birds:** K.N. Viswanathan | Sandeep Radhakrishnan | Sudhir Thapa | Piyali Tuli | Haridas Pal



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

The school team bested its rivals in final

They reached the fag end of the celebrations

S. Upendran

“Congratulations! I heard you guys won the tournament. Were you the only team participating? I can’t imagine...”
“Very funny! In all, there were 32 teams. We bested the five teams we had to play. We...”
“Bested five teams? What are you talking about? How can...”
“When you say that you ‘bested’ someone, what you mean is that you defeated the individual in a competition or fight.”
“The word can also be used in the context of a game, I suppose?”
“Yes, it certainly can! My sister and I played a game of chess. She bested me quite convincingly.”
“How about this example? You’ll have to put in a lot more effort if you want to best Sowmya in the next round.”
“It’s no shame to be bested by the best team in the tournament.”
“That’s true! Since we’re talking about sports, did you watch the Laver Cup over the weekend?”
“I caught the fag end of the trophy presentation.”
“Fag end? Is it a new expression?”
“No, it’s not! It’s been around for some time. When you say that you were present for the fag end of the event, what you’re suggesting...”
“You probably mean you walked in when the event had nearly ended. You were there for the last part.”
“But the expression ‘fag end’ carries with it a negative meaning as well. The ‘fag end’ of something is the most boring part of something.”
“In other words, when you talk about the fag end of an event, you’re talking about the worst part of the event.”
“That’s right! It’s the final and worst part of an event. Here’s an example. It had been a long day, and the Chairman was in no hurry to make a decision at the fag end of the day. We decided to meet early the next morning.”
“By the time the speaker reached the fag end of his talk, some of the members in the audience had already fallen asleep.”
“I like to be early for everything. Unlike some people, I hate to walk in at the fag end of a talk. I think that’s plain rude.”
“If you ask me, there are some events when it’s better to arrive late than early.”
“Really? Like what? A political rally?”
“I’ve got better things to do than attend a political rally. No, I was thinking about arriving on time for a wedding reception.”
“Based on my experience, if you arrive on time for a reception, you’re likely to be the only one in the hall. You won’t find anybody else. Not even the bride and groom.”
“That’s true! The couple and their parents will be at the beauty salon making themselves presentable. The best thing to do would be to leave and return back after some time.”
“Why do you say ‘return back’?”
“In other words, the word ‘return’ means ‘to come back’.”
“Exactly! The word ‘back’ is redundant or unnecessary. Here’s an example. The guests returned later than expected.”
“After the meeting with the client, I’ll be going home. I will not be returning to office.”
“That’s an excellent example. No point in returning to this place at the fag end of the day.”
upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Banal: repeated too often; overfamiliar through overuse

Synonyms: boring, bland, insipid, dull, tiring

Usage: She was tired of hearing the same banal advice.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/banal

International Phonetic Alphabet: /bəˈnɑːl/



For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

Shouldn't CIAL stop collecting user fee?



Making money: Terminal 3 of Cochin International Airport for International departures. H. VIBHU.

Paul Antony

The year 2025-26 seems to have been good for Cochin International Airport Limited (CIAL), which made a record profit of ₹502 crore and, in another record, declared a dividend of 55%. On a turnover of ₹1,220 crore, it implies a remarkable 41% margin. In contrast, GMR Airports Ltd., the closest peer, which operates Delhi and Hyderabad airports, registered just 1.57% profit margin.

This prompted me to take a closer look at tariff fixation at Indian airports.

Airports are capital intensive and investors need to be fairly compensated. Accordingly, the regulator – Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) – sets tariffs, including user development fees, based on the investments projected in the airport operator's core aeronautical activities. In the case of CIAL, the AERA had approved an investment of ₹1,416 crore for 2022-26, and a user fee of ₹270 for domestic and ₹570 for international passengers.

During 2025-26, the user fee collected was ₹236 crore, but CIAL executed only about 40% of the approved aeronautical works. The excess collection led to the record profit and dividend.

The unspent amount should, therefore, have been excluded from the profit, else CIAL should have stopped levying the user fee.

When Kochi airport started operations in 1999, there was no AERA. CIAL collected a user fee of ₹500 per passenger and issued a receipt for it. Today, the user fee is incorporated in the flight fare and most passengers will not even realise they are paying it. In 2005, the then CM Oommen Chandy discontinued the user fee when CIAL began making profits. Collection was restarted in 2022. The user fee would attract less opposition if it were earmarked for something productive, such as the construction of a second runway.

The sole runway at Kochi airport is due for re-carpeting in 2028. Once the work starts, no flights will be permitted between 10 am and 6 pm, leading to major disruptions. Yet CIAL has not made any effort to develop a second runway. As a first step, it must acquire around 300 acre.

When the issue of dividend is discussed, it is often argued that the non-resident Indian (NRI) investors who have made CIAL a reality should not be denied returns when the airport is doing well. But it would be instructive to examine how the funding was raised.

The metrics

The airport was commissioned on May 25, 1999, at a cost of ₹305 crore. CIAL's equity on March 31 that year was ₹66 crore. Interest-free deposits of ₹21 crore came from service providers like Air India and the duty-free shop contractor. The rest comprised loans raised from HUDCO, State Bank of Travancore and Federal Bank at about 18 per cent interest. The investor directors, mostly NRIs, held equity of only ₹11 crore, or 3.61% of project cost. The private investors increase their holding only after CIAL started making profits in 2002-03.

While CIAL today has about 16,000 shareholders, about 26% of the equity is held by the top three private shareholders and they alone receive ₹68 crore dividend.

(The writer is a former chief secretary of Kerala)

How algorithmic culture is forcing marketers to rewrite their playbook

Gen Z today is fuelling the collapse of collective authority itself; no one can pinpoint when they became a cohort, but they are connected and self-aware in ways Gen X and millennials never experienced before; this cohesion is unprecedented and leading to tremors; is Gen Z overhyped?

OPINION

Giraj Sharma

Few would have imagined that student protests over a fragile examination system and paper leaks would escalate so dramatically. The agitation at Delhi's Jantar Mantar soon toppled an Education Minister and jolted a complacent government. And the unrest continues, with widespread protests calling for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation over controversial Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Yet the deeper shock is generational. Baby boomers, Gen X and millennials are realising how little they grasp Gen Z's mindset, aspiration and attitude.

Society shifts. Culture evolves. Marketers are supposed to have the knack to adapt to these. Generational transitions aren't new, but the speed, scale and unfamiliarity of this one has left even veteran marketers and consumer behaviour experts unsettled.

The disruption caused by Gen Z drove the formation of the Marketing Academy's Discussion & Debate (MADD) – an informal forum for marketers, researchers, and advertisers to exchange ideas and explore whether the old rules



Marketer's dilemma: Police detain a demonstrator during a protest for the resignation of CEC. REUTERS

of branding are dead when it comes to Gen Z. The general consensus at MADD was that brands are struggling to decode Gen Z.

In their eagerness, some strayed from core identity and pretended to be 'friends' with Gen Z only to be met with rejection. For this generation, such efforts feel inauthentic, even cringe. Authenticity is non-negotiable as it always was, but with this generation the rejection is instantaneous.

Engage Gen Z

The challenge for marketers is to not mimic Gen Z, but engage with them meaningfully while staying true to their own DNA. A brand can remain traditional and yet resonate with Gen Z if it connects with honesty, re-



Audacious as it may sound, it is more likely that Gen Z doesn't follow brands but allows brands to follow them, that too selectively

levance, transparency and respect.

Gen Z not only want brands to be authentic in what they say, but also how they behave.

They care about ethical choices: no child labour, environmental responsibility, no animal cruelty and greater transparency. Brands are expected to make these commitments visible across labels, packaging, websites and social

media.

Where to meet them?

Now, here's a paradox. Gen Z may live on social media, but they don't want brands living in their space. Brand communication must be interesting and informative without becoming intrusive – stay relevant without appearing to be relentless. Social media may be public, but for Gen Z, it is their very personal space. Brands have started using algorithms and programmatic advertising to target Gen Z with greater accuracy than before, but this may have started to feel like surveillance, making Gen Z uncomfortable rather than connected.

The new order apparently has demolished social hierarchies and tradi-

Filmmakers strive to zero in on target audiences

Amit Vijay Mohile



Cost factor: It costs ₹15-20 lakh to produce a microdrama, against ₹2-5 crore for a premium web series. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Bollywood veteran Ajay Devgn has spent more than three decades making films for the Hindi mass market. At FICCI FRAMES, the convention on the business of media and entertainment held in Mumbai, where the *Singham* star was promoting *Drishyam* 3, he acknowledged a big problem: figuring out what the mass audience wants.

"I personally feel that making a Hindi film is the most difficult," Devgn said. Unlike regional cinema, which can speak to a more familiar audience and its tastes, Hindi cinema must connect with urban India, towns, suburbs and viewers whose preferences can differ sharply.

"How do you get across to everybody?"

National award-winning filmmaker Shoojit Sircar says he hasn't figured it out either, when *businessline* asked the *Piku*, *Vicky Donor* and *Sardar Udham* director how filmmakers should navigate the splinter in audiences across geography, languages, theatres and streaming.

There is nearly ₹59,000 crore riding on finding that viewer.

Bollywood studios are backing films and franchises. Streaming platforms are investing in premium series. Investors are financing cheaper microdramas. And AI promises to multiply the amount of content

that can be produced and tested.

Their economics differ, but all are chasing the same finite resource: the Indian viewer's attention.

Finding what travels

As viewership fragments, creators are finding that stories may travel farther by becoming more specific, not more generic.

Sircar points to Satyajit Ray, who made films in Kolkata without trying to manufacture an "international" film, yet became a global reference point. "Film is not a stock market; it's someone's love, someone's passion," Sircar says.

Chef and filmmaker Ranveer Brar offers a culinary version: "A *dosa* does not become more global by becoming less south Indian. We become more glo-

bal by becoming more Indian." Netflix India vice-president for content Monika Shergill arrives at much the same place. "Scale becomes a prison to ideas," she says, arguing that specificity, emotional depth and a strong creator's point of view can help stories travel.

Experimentation cost

Online video has grown into an estimated \$6 billion market in 2026, against television's \$4.8 billion, according to consulting firm Media Partners Asia.

Monthly online video audience has reached 664.9 million, while connected TV reaches 206.9 million. MPA CEO Vivek Couto estimates roughly \$2.6 billion is being invested in online video content. Microdramas radically

lower the cost of testing audience approval.

It costs ₹15-20 lakh to produce a microdrama, against ₹2-5 crore for a premium web series.

The business models differ too. Premium streaming uses shows to acquire and retain subscribers, and potentially build intellectual property. Microdrama platforms can find viewers via social feeds and monetise by charging for watching an episode beyond the initial teaser. Among 2,000 microdrama viewers aged 18-44 surveyed by Meta and Ormax, 89% had discovered the format through social feeds. The study doesn't establish how many paid subsequently or became regular viewers. (The writer is with *The Hindu businessline*)

How Mark Rothko's abstract art beat the Instagram algorithm

OPINION

Shubho Sengupta

For the last few weeks I have been trying to understand the social media algorithm. I have been reading Dan Koe on the attention economy and Kane Kallaway on virality.

I started wondering what would be the perfect example of the algorithm. Something that demonstrates the logic of the machine itself.

And then I realised it might be the long dead American abstract painter Mark Rothko. The Rothko viral trend on Instagram, that is. Which is strange, because Rothko seems to be everything the algorithm should dislike. His

paintings are large, quiet and slow. There are no faces, no plot, no action. Often there are just blobs, rectangles of colour, floating into one another.

Social media craze

Yet Rothko has become a social media phenomenon. His paintings are being turned into outfits, personalities, playlists and memes. Creators are assigning moods and identities to individual Rothkos.

The algorithm doesn't see content

The mistake is to think the algorithm rewards a particular kind of content. Okay, it doesn't really know whether something is a Rothko painting, a cat video or a political rant. It watches behaviour.

Do people stop? Do they



No Instagram version: Put a Rothko into an Instagram feed and it looks almost wrong. AFP

stay? Do they react? Do they share? Do they return? The definition: a machine for measuring attention.

And Rothko turns out to

be very good at attracting it. Put a Rothko into an Instagram feed and it looks almost wrong. We are used to faces, movement, food, travel and people talking

into cameras. There is suddenly a large field of colour. It is recognisable, but different enough to interrupt the visual flow.

Then Rothko makes you

stay

This is where Rothko becomes more interesting. Stay with the painting and colours begin to shift. Edges become uncertain. The apparently flat surface acquires depth. Rothko captures attention and then removes stimulation.

Then comes emotion. Rothko didn't tell the viewer what to feel. A Rothko can be melancholy to one person and peaceful to another. The viewer supplies the missing meaning.

So it becomes: Which Rothko are you? A colour combination becomes a mood, a personality, a wardrobe, even a soundtrack. The artwork becomes a piece of identity.

The painting becomes a format

It made me think about

Today, the distance between making, distributing and consuming has disappeared

Indian abstraction too. V.S. Gaitonde is an obvious reference, although I wouldn't call him an Indian Rothko. But his luminous, layered, non-objective paintings possess the quality of making the viewer stop. Nasreen Mohamed offers another example: lines, grids and space. Her work seems incompatible with Instagram's visual excess, yet its language is extraordinarily distinctive.

We now live in an algorithmic culture. Once, media was one-way: newspapers wrote, television

broadcast, publishers published, and the audience received. Today, the distance between making, distributing and consuming has disappeared.

How algorithms learn

A news story is clipped, commented upon and re-framed. A brand campaign is remixed by its audience. The algorithm learns from these reactions and feeds them forward. The audience is no longer simply receiving media; it is helping make it, shape it and give it meaning.

The audience has become the medium. As Marshall McLuhan said – sometime in the '50s – the medium is the message.

(Shubho Sengupta is a digital marketer with an analogue past.)

UAE had shared details of pilots, ahead of flydubai flight, with Israel



Nearly 1,500 Myanmar nationals return despite security concerns



Ethiopia's govt. retakes Mekelle after opposition fighters withdraw



China says 'divergent opinions' led to lack of consensus at G20



Critics have accused the police of using heavy-handed tactics against children.



Jay Clayton is widely reported to be the new AI czar in the administration of President Donald Trump. AP

‘White House AI task force will curb overregulation’

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

A White House task force on artificial intelligence will assess the technology’s risks and opportunities, while preventing overregulation that stifles innovation, its leader Jay Clayton has told the *Wall Street Journal*.

U.S. President Donald Trump on Sunday confirmed Mr. Clayton, the national intelligence chief, as head of the task force on AI, amid increasingly vocal warnings from researchers about the technology’s potential dangers.

Mr. Clayton is the second person to hold the informal title after venture capitalist David Sacks, who held the role at the start of Mr. Trump’s second term before stepping down.

The new “Super Intelligence Force” – using Mr. Trump’s preferred term for artificial intelligence – will have 120 days to report on the risks and opportunities of the technology, the Journal reported on Saturday.

“The president asked that a group be put together that was going to ensure exactly what he said... (that) we stay the leaders in superintelligence, and that the interests of the American people are put first,” Mr. Clayton said.

“The risk of not being first is high,” he added. “Not being first increases the identified, and unidentified, risks, particularly from our adversaries. Being first will better enable us to address those risks on behalf of the American people.”

A longtime Wall Street lawyer, Mr. Clayton represented Goldman Sachs during the 2008 financial crisis and Barclays in its purchase of Lehman Brothers’ assets. The White House did not immediately respond to AFP’s request for comment.

Bosnia votes as pro-Russian politician looms large and ethnic tensions rise

The ethnically divided nation will elect a three-member presidency representing Bosniaks, Serbs and Croats; Serbian nationalist Milorad Dodik, who recently returned from meeting Putin in Russia, wields significant influence, though banned from running for office; Bosnia formally seeks to join EU

Associated Press
SARAJEVO

Voters in Bosnia cast ballots on Sunday in a general election in which most are focused on everyday problems, while some mainstream politicians in the Balkan nation have whipped up war-era tensions that have kept the country divided since its brutal 1992-95 conflict.

Around 3.4 million voters are choosing the three members of the country’s multi-ethnic presidency, lawmakers for the national Parliament, and heads of institutions for the country’s two entities: the Muslim-majority Federation of Bosnia-Herzegovina, and Republika Srpska, which is dominated by ethnic Serbs.

Bosnia has a complex web of governing institutions that were created by a U.S.-brokered peace agreement in 1995 in an effort to manage the ethnic divisions between Muslim Bosniaks, Orthodox Serbs and Catholic Croats that gave rise to the war.

On Sunday morning, Associated Press journalists reported seeing multiple polling places where voting could not begin on time due to difficulties with new digital voting technology, a measure introduced to address earlier concerns over vote tampering.

Polls will close at 7 p.m.

Taking centre stage in the contest is a staunchly pro-Russian politician who, despite not appearing on the ballot, has dominated the campaign and inflamed divisions that have sparked fears of renewed instability.

Separatist Serb leader

Milorad Dodik, the separatist and nationalist former president of the Serb-majority Republika Srpska, has been banned from holding public office after being convicted of defying decisions by the international envoy overseeing the 1995 peace agreement.

Mr. Dodik has just returned from a trip to Moscow, where he met with Russian President Vladimir Putin. His party, the Alliance of Independent Social Democrats, is likely to win the election in Republika Srpska.

At his party’s final election rally on Friday night in Banja Luka, Republika Srpska’s administrative capital, Mr. Dodik told supporters that Bosnia “is dead.”

“It is an impossible country. It doesn’t make any sense,” Mr. Dodik said at the rally, which was also attended by the Russian ambassador to Bosnia, Igor Khalabukov.

Dragan Bursac, an analyst, said that despite Mr. Dodik not appearing on the ballot for the first time in nearly 30 years, he “is



Influential leader: Milorad Dodik, Leader of Alliance of Independent Social Democrats, votes during Bosnia and Herzegovina’s 2026 general election in Banja Luka on Sunday. REUTERS

still in command. He is everywhere.”

“It is obvious that these measures to ban him from political life are not working, and he is using them,” Mr. Bursac said.

After casting her ballot on Sunday, Mr. Dodik’s ally Zeljka Cvijanovic, who is running for re-election as the Serb member of Bosnia’s three-member presidency, called the vote “very important” for “a peaceful and stable Republika Srpska.”

While Bosnia has been peaceful in recent years, some of its politicians have kept alive the divisions between the country’s Bosniaks, who are mainly Muslim, and its Serbs and Croats. Bosnian Serb lead-

ers like Mr. Dodik have pushed for the separation of their entity from the rest of Bosnia, which has led to concerns among Western countries that tensions could once again spill over.

One of the poorest countries in Europe, Bosnia is still struggling to recover decades after the war that started in 1992, after the country declared independence from the Serb-led former Yugoslavia and ethnic Serbs took up arms to carve out their own state and join Serbia. The conflict killed more than 1,00,000 people and displaced millions.

Bosnia is formally seeking to join the European Union, but progress has been stalled despite EU ef-

forts to encourage Bosnia’s divided leaders to work together for reform.

“We should change the old faces,” Durak Miler, a resident of the Bosnian capital of Sarajevo, said. “They have been governing for 35 years ... I think whoever comes next will work better for retired people and the poor.”

Electronic voting

Bakir Izetbegovic, leader of the Bosniak nationalist Party of Democratic Action, said he expected people “to choose what is safe and reliable for them at these elections.”

“I think people in Bosnia should not experiment, but rely on those who have proven themselves already,” said Mr. Izetbegovic, who is running for the Bosniak seat in the three-member presidency.

Bosnia’s wartime wounds were recently revived by a public homage in Serbia and among Bosnian Serbs to the wartime army commander Ratko Mladic, who died in late August while serving a life sentence for genocide and other war crimes.

Bosnian Serbs view Mladic as a hero despite his conviction by a U.N. court over the massacre of more than 8,000 Muslim men and boys in Srebrenica in 1995, and other atrocities.

Authorities are for the first time using electronic identification of voters and ballot scanners to prevent irregularities or organised voter manipulation, which have cast doubt on the fairness of previous elections.

On Sunday, some voters in Banja Luka expressed concern that the new digital systems could confuse older voters. Republika Srpska’s interior ministry said in a press release that of 1,957 polling stations in the entity, there had been delays at 201.

Voter Radomir Vukelic said he was satisfied. “This is why I expect the results to be correct. You’ve got a scanner, you’ve got a paper, you’ve got it all,” he said. Most of Bosnia’s 75 political parties running in the election are organised along ethnic lines.

Imran Khan supporters begin march to Islamabad demanding his release

Associated Press
ISLAMABAD

Hundreds of supporters of imprisoned former Pakistani Prime Minister Imran Khan began a days-long march toward Islamabad on Sunday to demand his release after talks between the government and the opposition fell through.

Mr. Khan is current Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif’s main political rival and has been imprisoned since 2023 on corruption and other charges that he and his party say are politically motivated. He remains popular.

The march began in Lakki Marwat district in northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, where



Imran Khan’s supporters take part in a long march in Lakki Marwat in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province on Sunday. AFP

Mr. Khan’s party holds power, with overnight stops planned along the route. Sohail Afridi, the province’s chief minister and a Khan supporter, announced the plan on X.

In its wake, authorities have erected roadblocks,

using containers, at the entrance to Islamabad and inside the city.

Mr. Khan’s Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party, or PTI, and the federal government were in talks to postpone the march but failed to reach a resolution two

days ago. Gohar Khan, the party’s chairman, said negotiations remained deadlocked after two rounds.

Mr. Sharif urged postponement, citing a surge in militant attacks in the northwest, where the Pakistani Taliban have stepped up attacks. His government has accused PTI of sympathizing with the Pakistani Taliban, also known as Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan.

The organisers now vow to reach the capital after rallying with hundreds of thousands of Mr. Khan’s supporters.

Besides Mr. Khan’s release, protesters are demanding his transfer to a hospital and permission for his family to visit him.

Human tower



Rising high: People form a human tower called castell during a biannual competition in Tarragona, Spain, on Sunday. REUTERS

Fifty years after massacre at university, Thai youth still fight for right to dissent

Agence France-Presse
BANGKOK

Fifty years after a student demonstration against dictatorship ended in a massacre, Thailand’s latest generation of protesters say they still face threats including prosecution, jail or exile.

Nutthanit Duangmusit, 24, spent several months in pre-trial detention before being convicted under Thailand’s strict royal defamation law, among almost 300 people charged under so-called *lese majeste* since 2020.

She is currently out on bail while she has appealed against her conviction and has been helping organise commemorations for Tuesday’s anniversary of the October 6, 1976, killings at Thammasat University.

In one of the darkest

chapters in modern Thai history, security forces and right-wing mobs massacred student protesters at one of the nation’s top universities.

“Back then, guns were fired and bodies lay on the ground,” Ms. Nutthanit said as she walked AFP through the campus in Bangkok. “Today, the violence comes through the law.”

The Thai government did not respond immediately to a request for comment on the use of legal measures against activists.

The crackdown 50 years ago followed the return of military dictator Thanom Kittikachorn, who had been ousted three years earlier.

Students gathered at Thammasat to oppose his return. At dawn on Octo-

ber 6, police and right-wing groups stormed the campus, shooting, beating and lynching protesters.

‘Dare to talk’

The official death toll was 46, although survivors and witnesses believe more than 100 were killed.

No state official has been held accountable.

Government spokesman Ekkapob Pianpises told AFP that many of those involved in the incident have since died or could not be located.

The current government wants to find ways to prevent such violent incidents, he said.

“We do not want to see loss of life happen because people have different opinions.”

Ms. Nutthanit was involved in youth-led protests that began in 2020,



Activist Nutthanit Duangmusit (left); survivors of the 1976 massacre sharing their memories during a commemorative gathering at Thammasat University in Bangkok on September 20. AFP



which drew tens of thousands onto the streets to demand democratic change and reform of the monarchy.

In 2022, Ms. Nutthanit, then 20, and others polled Bangkok passers-by about royal motorcades and the exercise of royal power.

That and other political activities led to three con-

victions under *lese majeste*, which critics say is interpreted so broadly it has become a tool to target dissent.

“As someone who went through every step of the justice system, from police and prosecutors to courts and prison, I can say that it is unjust and rotten,” Ms. Nutthanit said.

When many young protesters ended up in court, they were helped by lawyers including Krisadang Nutcharut – a 68-year-old Thammasat survivor.

Ahead of the anniversary, he expressed admiration for their courage, telling AFP that *lese majeste* reform was something “no one dares raise in my generation.”

The monarchy remains widely revered in Thailand, a largely traditionalist society where a conservative government was elected this year.

‘Dying for justice’

Thiraphop Tengprawat, 21, was charged with *lese majeste* over a satirical banner displayed on another Thammasat campus last October after the university cancelled student events following the death of

Queen Sirikit, the current king’s mother.

Police alleged the banner insulted Sirikit.

“The problems we face today have a history,” said Mr. Thiraphop, who is still waiting to hear if he will face trial.

“They were made worse by laws enacted in the climate of fear after the massacre. That violence was written into law – and it has endured for 50 years.”

The military seized power on the evening of the massacre and increased the punishment for royal defamation 15 days later.

Order No. 41 introduced a minimum jail term of three years and raised the maximum from seven to 15 years – a law that remains in force.

“The version of *lese majeste* enforced today is a legacy of that coup,” said 23-

year-old reform campaigner Nasree Phumkuea.

Recent attempts to amend the *lese majeste* law have landed dozens of former and current MPs in court.

The fight continues. Ms. Nutthanit, Mr. Thiraphop and Ms. Nasree are among activists who joined massacre survivors campaigning to repeal the junta order behind *lese majeste*’s current penalties.

For Ms. Nutthanit, the battle is increasingly personal. In May 2024, her close friend Netiporn Sane-sangkhom died in custody following a prolonged hunger strike. She was 28.

“Fifty years later, people are still dying for justice or being forced into exile,” Ms. Nutthanit said.

“It feels as though Thailand keeps returning to the same place.”

We didn't get the Asian Games gold on a platter, says Samson



We had full confidence that
we would win gold: Salima



India's Asiad medal-winning boxers receive a warm welcome



Uruguay team lands in Kolkata, tries its hand at cricket



CM
YK

Batters continue to sparkle, bowling remains a concern

Apart from Kuldeep in the first ODI, none of the bowlers looked threatening; India skipper Gill will expect more from his pace arsenal, sans Bumrah, which failed to take up responsibility and leaked runs in all the three matches

WI IN INDIA

S. Dipak Ragav
NEW CHANDIGARH

With just about a year to go for the 2027 ODI World Cup, India's preparation for the quadrennial event got off on the right note as it posted a 2-1 series win over the West Indies.

There were, however, some warning signs that the team will want to address soon.

The big positive was the batting. The top-order set up the series victory, led by skipper Shubman Gill, who scored two centuries, including a double hundred.

More importantly, Rohit Sharma (225 runs) and Virat Kohli (168) were on song. Since this is the only format they play, it is imperative the senior players maximise every opportunity.

K.L. Rahul got only one chance and proved why he is so vital to the team, scoring an unbeaten 129, even if it went in vain.

However, bowling remains a concern. Granted, the pitches at all three venues had very little for the bowlers. Still, the attack is



Job done: India's quality was enough to pull off a 2-1 victory. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Difficult times: Siraj could not shine in the lone opportunity he got. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

hardly settled.

Apart from Kuldeep Yadav in the first match, none of the others looked like they could keep the batters honest or provide timely breakthroughs.

The other fast bowlers not being able to take up

responsibility showed how the Men in Blue are over-reliant on Jasprit Bumrah, who was away on Asian Games duty.

The management handed out debuts to Auqib Nabi and Anshul Kamboj, both of whom proved ex-

pensive while Mohammed Siraj's recent struggle continued in the only match he played.

Captain Gill admitted as much, saying he would have wanted to see more out of his speedsters.

"Bowling in the Power-

Play and in the death has been hurting us. If you don't get off to a good start in the PowerPlay, it's not easy to take wickets in the middle overs as we have seen," said Gill.

"It's not easy to create chances with only four fielders outside. The intensity of the game, and how it goes, becomes completely different if you don't keep taking wickets in either the PowerPlay or the middle overs," he added.

Going forward, the think-tank needs to quickly identify the right combination for the World Cup and give them enough games to get into a groove, something Gill stressed he wants to do from the next series.

Our fielding has not been up to the mark, admits Gill

S. Dipak Ragav
NEW CHANDIGARH

Even as India celebrated yet another home ODI series triumph, skipper Shubman Gill did not hold back on the things the team needs to improve.

Foremost among them was the fielding standard, which the captain felt was poor in the three outings against the West Indies.

"I think we dropped around three or four catches today (Saturday). Dropping catches breaks the momentum," said Gill following his side's five-wicket loss to West Indies in the third and final ODI here.

"Our fielding in the series, I would say, has not been up to the mark. I think we dropped around seven catches in the whole series, if I'm not wrong."

Affects the bowlers

Gill also highlighted that ground fielding needs to get better and spoke about how it affects the bowlers.

"Even in the field today, we gave away many runs. We were quite sloppy. I think leading up to the World Cup, these are the areas where we definitely need to get better. We need to be at our best, especially on the field. If the wicket isn't helping the bowlers and our fielding is substandard, it becomes difficult for them," he pointed out. On experimenting with



Vital aspect: Gill says it is paramount to back up the bowlers with good catching and effective ground fielding. AFP

India-West Indies ODI series in numbers

Batting	Inns	Runs	HS	Avg	SR	100s/50s
Gill	3	334	223*	167.00	135.22	2/0
Hope	3	278	162*	139.00	112.09	2/0
Jangoo	3	239	114	119.50	135.79	1/2
Rohit	3	225	101	75.00	115.38	1/1
Bowling	Inns	Wkts	BB	Avg	Econ	4W
Kuldeep	3	7	4/40	23.85	5.56	1
Seales	3	4	3/62	43.00	6.88	0
Prasidh	2	3	2/60	35.00	7.00	0
Gurnoor	3	3	2/96	73.33	7.54	0



The skipper stepping up is not anything new to him, but to keep for 50 overs and then go and play an innings like that was special

SAMMY
WI coach on Hope

players for the all-rounder's slots, Gill said, "Anshul (Kamboj) and Auqib

(Nabi) are the kind of players who are going to be in the mix a lot. We want someone who can bowl and can bat a bit at No. 8. That number is very crucial for us.

"But I honestly don't think there is that much time to experiment. Hopefully we get all the players that are available from the next series, and we want to start playing with the combination that we want for the World Cup".

Mukesh and Akash blow away J&K as RoI triumphs



No clue: Jammu & Kashmir captain Dogra falls to Mukesh for a golden duck. IMRAN NISSAR

IRANI CUP

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep have multiple threads tying them together. Both pacers hail from mofussil towns in Bihar. Both relocated to West Bengal to pursue cricket. Both have donned the whites for India.

Their bonhomie with the ball in hand has given Bengal many victories in the Ranji Trophy. At the picturesque Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium on Sunday, the two quicks again combined to devastating effect to help Rest of India clinch a 167-run victory over Jammu & Kashmir on day four and win the Irani Cup. While the 32-year-old Mukesh took six for 33, Akash, 29, finished with figures of three for 25. J&K's run chase of 279 was derailed altogether as the 2025-26 Ranji champion folded up for 111.

RoI, which resumed on 306 for eight, was bowled out for 319. Centurion R. Smaran added nine runs to his overnight tally of 126 before he was castled by Sunil Kumar.

In pursuit, J&K raced to 54 for none in 10 overs. Qamran Iqbal enjoyed the upper hand in a duel



Mukesh. IMRAN NISSAR

an hour after lunch, with the two friends savouring the win side by side.

The scores:
Rest of India —1st innings: 237.
Jammu & Kashmir — 1st innings: 278.

RoI — 2nd innings: Shikhar Mohan c Wadhawan b Sunil 2, Sanat Sangwan c Wadhawan b Umar 55, Sudip Gharami b Nasir 33, Saransh Jain b Umar 25, Sarfaraz Khan c Pundir b Umar 0, R. Smaran b Sunil 135, Manav Suthar lbw b Lotra 16, Rishabh Pant lbw b Lotra 8, Akash Deep c Khajuria b Lotra 1, Mukesh Choudhary b Sunil 11, Mukesh Kumar (not out) 2; Extras (b-2, lb-5, w-3, nb-21): 31; Total (in 99.5 overs): 319.

Fall of wickets: 1-8, 2-58, 3-128, 4-130, 5-131, 6-183, 7-195, 8-197, 9-310.

J&K bowling: Umar 25-2-92-3, Sunil 28.5-5-56-3, Nasir 11-0-55-1, Abid 8-0-32-0, Lotra 26-5-71-3, Pundir 1-0-6-0.
J&K — 2nd innings: Qamran Iqbal lbw b Akash 32, Shubham Khajuria c sub (Juyal) b Akash 36, Shubham Pundir lbw b Mukesh 9, Paras Dogra b Mukesh 0, Abdul Samad c Shikhar b Choudhary 20, Kanhaiya Wadhawan c sub (Juyal) b Mukesh 2, Sahil Lotra c sub (Juyal) b Akash 0, Lone Nasir (not out) 1, Abid Mushtaq b Mukesh 5, Umar Nazir c Sarfaraz b Mukesh 0, Sunil Kumar c Shikhar b Mukesh 0; Extras (b-5, nb-1): 6; Total (in 28.4 overs): 111.

Fall of wickets: 1-54, 2-65, 3-65, 4-89, 5-98, 6-103, 7-106, 8-111, 9-111.
RoI bowling: Mukesh 10.4-1-33-6, Choudhary 8-1-48-1, Akash 9-1-25-3, Manav 1-1-0-0.
PoM: Smaran.

TN bags u-23 crown with outright victory

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu u-23 team began its season on the best possible note, comprehensively beating Rest of India u-23 by six wickets on the final day at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium here.

Fixed a target of 149 in 46 overs for an outright victory, the home team did more than enough in the last two sessions on Sunday. Having conceded the first-innings lead, RoI had no option but to make TN bat again to stand any chance of bagging the trophy.

The away side did so after declaring its second essay at 431 for seven, built on a splendid double century from opener Angkrish Raghuvanshi (203, 281b, 16x4, 4x6) and a ton off the bat of No. 4 Digvijay Patil (106, 138b, 8x4).

Left-arm spinner P. Vignesh (five for 144) was the chief contributor for TN, with his victims including Raghuvanshi.

The scores: Rest of India u-23 179 & 431/7 decl. in 90 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 203, Ayush Jethwa 58, Digvijay Patil 106, P. Vignesh 5/144) lost to Tamil Nadu u-23 462 & 150/4 in 34.5 overs (K.T.A. Madhava Prasad 42). **PoM:** Madhava Prasad.



Dominant show: Tamil Nadu was in control of the match from start to finish. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Verstappen claims first win of the year

FORMULA ONE

Agence France-Presse
SEPANG (MALAYSIA)

Max Verstappen secured his and Red Bull's first win this year with an imperious drive in chaotic conditions in a storm-delayed Bahrain GP in Malaysia on Sunday.

Nine years after winning the last F1 race at the Sepang Circuit, the Dutchman came through a wild afternoon of accidents and incidents for his 72nd victory and first since Abu Dhabi last year. In a race of shifting tyre strategies, Verstappen came home 2.307s ahead of championship leader Kimi Antonelli of Mercedes and Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton.

The results (provisional, 55 laps): 1. Verstappen (Red Bull) 1h:47m:14.808s; 2. Antonelli (Mercedes) + 2.307s; 3. Hamilton (Ferrari) 4.919; 4. Leclerc (Ferrari) 7.258; 5. Hadjar (Red Bull) 8.571; 6. Piastri (McLaren) 9.454; 7. Lawson (Racing Bulls) 12.753; 8. Alonso (Aston Martin) 13.372; 9. Norris (McLaren) 13.993; 10. Lindblad (Racing Bulls) 15.928; 11. Hulkenberg (Audi) 17.404; 12. Stroll (Aston Martin) 18.052; 13. Colapinto (Alpine) 18.997; 14. Bearman (Haas) 22.305; 15. Ocon (Haas) 22.532; 16. Gasly (Alpine) 23.315; 17. Sainz (Williams) 25.431; 18. Bortoletto (Audi) 28.233; 19. Perez (Cadillac) 29.310; **DNF:** Russell (Mercedes); Albon (Williams); Bottas (Cadillac).

The standings: Drivers: 1. Antonelli 320; 2. Russell 236; 3. Hamilton 214; 4. Leclerc 191; 5. Norris 188. **Constructors:** 1. Mercedes 556; 2. Ferrari 405; 3. McLaren 316; 4. Red Bull 298; 5. Racing Bulls 90.

Andre backs team to extend its dominance

S. Shrivathsan
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu u-23 team just cannot stop clinching titles. Having achieved a double in the previous season, it added a trophy to its cabinet after defeating Rest of India u-23 in a match that mirrored the Irani Cup.

C. Andre Siddarth, who led the State to its latest triumph on Sunday, believes the current crop is capable of extending its dominance. "They have experience... the way they won the tournaments last year speaks for itself. They are good enough to win the tournaments again," said Andre, proudly sporting a victor's medal around his neck.

The u-23 unit will begin its Col. C.K. Nayudu Trophy defence in a home game against Saurashtra in Dindigul later this month. With Andre becoming a mainstay in the senior red-ball set-up, the age-group side will be led by all-rounder S. Mohamed Ali.

"These guys are too good to be honest. I have been playing with them since my u-12 days. They know what they need to do... these aren't guys who need to be told what is expected of them," Andre added.

For RoI opener Angkrish Raghuvanshi, it was about getting back in the groove.

The Mumbai lad had been out of action for three months with a finger injury, but he is now finding his feet again. The double century against TN u-23 was a massive confidence booster. "I am playing [competitive cricket] after a long time and my knock gave me clarity. The middle of the pitch is my happy place," said Raghuvanshi.

"I tried to bat as long as I could. It was a satisfying experience because every batter dreams of hitting big hundreds. It was a good day for me, but it would have been better had we won the match," he added.

SNAPSHOTS

AIFF decides to hold elections on Dec. 20

The All India Football Federation (AIFF) will hold its elections on December 20, it was decided at a Special General Body Meeting in Kolkata on Sunday. Rajeev Sharma, former State Election Commissioner of Haryana, has been appointed Electoral Officer to oversee the conduct of the elections.

Vaidehee ready to reclaim National title

Two-time champion Vaidehee Chaudhari will look to reclaim the Fenesta Open National tennis championship when the tournament gets underway at DLTA in New Delhi on Monday. "I won in 2022 and 2024, but I couldn't play last year because of injury. I am happy to be back again, and my eyes are obviously on the winning trophy," Vaidehee said. The men's draw, meanwhile, is headlined by defending champion Manish Sureshkumar.



The journey in numbers after the 55-lap race at Sepang

1 Red Bull-Ford recorded its first win as a power unit manufacturer

1 The first time a country has hosted another country's F1 race since Italy hosted the 2006 San Marino GP

1 The Sepang International Circuit made its first appearance on the F1 calendar since 2017

38 Verstappen registered his 38th fastest lap, level with Vettel for fifth on the list of most fastest laps

72 Verstappen went level with Schumacher (Ferrari) for the second-most victories with a single constructor. Only Hamilton (84 with Mercedes) is ahead

100 Verstappen is the only driver with a 100% points-scoring rate at this track

829 Alonso goes past Button (812) for the most laps raced at Sepang



MAHARASHTRA

In Maharashtra's Marathwada region, child marriage persists as families grapple with fears over girls' safety and so-called honour. Poverty and migration add to the problem, while predators, weak institutions, and a marriage market deepen their vulnerability. **Radheshyam Jadhav** follows girls and women caught in this cycle and those fighting to break it through education and independence

Childhood: sold, silenced, stolen



A family in Beed district, Maharashtra, where poverty, migration, and concerns over girls' safety contribute to the persistence of child marriage. RADHESHYAM JADHAV

(Names of all minors in the story have been changed to protect their identity)

Most nights, Kirti, in her teens, is jolted awake by nightmares of a marriage ceremony she never chose: the raucous twang of a banjo band rattling out popular Hindi-film songs, garlands swaying chaotically, and a stranger, nearly twice her age, waiting at the other end of the *mandap*, where Kirti is dressed like the bride.

Kirti's nightmare is triggered by the harsh generational reality of child marriage, which continues to be practised by families across Maharashtra's drought-prone Marathwada region.

Here, child marriage is not simply a consequence of tradition. Families say fears over girls' safety, so-called family honour, migration, and economic insecurity leave them with few choices. Activists point to predators, weak institutional protection, and a growing marriage market that exploits vulnerable families.

The result is a cycle in which married minor girls often face violence or abandonment, and return to the same homes where the next generation of girls is growing up.

Despite laws and government campaigns aimed at ending child marriage, breaking the cycle remains a long and lonely battle for the girls who choose education and independence.

Kirti lives in Kathoda, 27 kilometres from the region's historical Beed district, with her maternal grandparents Suman and Achyut Ovhal.

Suman says her own mother was married at 13 and hated it. "But then there was no other option and I was married at the same age. *Mulgishyani-zali ki gharatthevta yet nahi* (Once a daughter attains puberty, she cannot be kept in the house)," says Suman. After she was married, she adds, her foremost responsibility was to deliver children, preferably sons. She birthed four daughters and then a son.

A majority of children born to underage mothers are not delivered in medical institutions, even though there are some government hospitals in the region. In fact, the Aadhaar cards of many women here mention only their 'tentative' ages.

Both Suman and Achyut work as daily-wage labourers, even though they own a 1.5-acre patch of dry land.

They migrate to western Maharashtra and other States like Karnataka and Telangana to work as sugarcane cutters during the six-month crushing season – October-November onwards.

Marathwada records high numbers of farmer suicides. In 2025, the region's eight districts recorded 1,129 farmer suicides between January 1 and December 31, with Beed being among the worst hit, as per government data.

In the remaining six months, Suman and Achyut work in their fields and take up odd jobs in their village. With an unsteady income and an uncertain future, Suman got all her daughters married before they turned 16. They have all returned to her with their children following marital disputes. Suman and her husband have been convincing their son-in-laws to reconcile with their respective spouses.

Trapped into tradition

Kirti's mother, Chaya, has been living with her parents for a few months. Every few months her husband leaves her and she returns to her maternal home. Suman refuses to say why he leaves or why the couple fight. She is worried he will not come back if he comes to know about the matter being discussed publicly.

Kirti has witnessed her mother suffer through domestic violence and it colours her views on marriage. She is reticent and refuses to speak to strangers.

At the mention of school, her eyes twinkle, yet she doesn't speak much. Circumstances have forced her to mature beyond her years and any talk of marriage brings her to tears.

Chaya blames her mother for "destroying" her life by not allowing her to finish school. Yet, even as Chaya complains, she remains unsure whether she can avoid repeating her mother's mistake and enable Kirti to study as she wishes. Chaya, who is a mother to three girls, including Kirti, works as a daily-wager and sometimes joins her husband as a sugarcane-cutter.

Suman does see child marriage as a social evil, but also explains how society is unsafe for girls. "There are predators all around. As daily-wage



There are predators all around... As daily-wage workers, we cannot take our daughters when we migrate for months as they are unsafe in a new place; we cannot leave them home, because they are unsafe alone

SUMAN OVHAL
Resident, Kathoda village, Yavatmal district, Maharashtra

workers, we cannot take our daughters when we migrate for months as they are unsafe in a new place; we cannot leave them home, because they are unsafe alone," she says.

For Achyut, the family's respect in society rests upon a singular, unyielding pillar – *ijjat* (honour) that is inextricably bound to a girl's character. The girl's character is measured solely by the preservation of her virginity. He believes that if a girl elopes, is molested, abducted, or raped, it is an insult to the family.

The best solution, in his view, is to marry the girl off as soon as possible so that the responsibility shifts to her husband.

Under the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006, marriages involving females under 18 or males under 21 are classified as child marriages and are associated with cycles of poverty, inequality, and health risks, particularly in rural and tribal regions. Under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, sexual acts with a wife under 18 constitute rape.

The Supreme Court has said that a husband committing penetrative assault on a child bride can face punishment for aggravated penetrative sexual assault under the POCSO Act, 2012. The Bal Vivah Mukht Bharat campaign by the Government of India aims to reduce the prevalence of child marriage by 10% by 2026 and make India child-marriage free by 2030. Maharashtra has the highest number of child marriage prevention officers at 21,196, as per government data.

But Achyut has a different take on the issue. "Everyone condemns child marriage and talks about ending this custom, but what about the predators who force parents into marrying off their daughters early?" he says.

Prey for predators

Tatwashil Kamble, a child rights activist based in Beed, highlights that addressing these issues exposes a deeper systemic crisis involving political influence in molestation, rape and abduction.

He points out that predators backed by political influence frequently target vulnerable minors and pressure them to flee, leaving poor parents largely powerless to speak out due to severe intimidation. In Aher Dhanora village, some four kilometres away from Beed, a local youth lured a 15-year-old girl away from home and raped her. He continued to sexually assault her in the following days. When she resisted, he blackmailed her, threatening to tell the village that she was no longer a virgin.

When her parents came to know about this, they planned to marry her off. The local youth returned and demanded they pay him.

In Kaij, about 50 kilometres from Beed, another family mustered the courage to seek justice for their 13-year-old daughter who was allegedly molested by a local goon. Yet, her parents were subjected to severe systemic apathy – the father and the girl were forced to wait 27 hours in the Kaij police station and government health centre simply to file a report and obtain medical docu-

mentation, say activists. They add that although cases of exploitation involving politically connected men, their associates, and local goons are widely discussed across Beed, fear prevents many families from speaking out.

Kamble notes that social media has fuelled the trend of minor girls eloping from their homes. "One-on-one communication has become easy because of WhatsApp and other platforms," he says, adding that movies romanticising running away from home influence girls, even though the films are about adult women.

According to police records, in 2025, approximately 266 minor girls went missing from Beed, out of which 214 were rescued. The police say many of these girls had fallen in love with local youth online.

"Parents like me who want to educate their daughters are unable to because of concerns over social security," says Asha Ugade, a sugarcane cutter from Kasari village, which is some six kilometres from Kaij. Married with her four sisters when she was in her early teens, Asha says her parents could not afford her education.

"My parents were landless labourers, so were my in-laws," she reflects. Having no memory of her wedding, she recalls working as a labourer in sugarcane fields with her husband. "I started cutting sugarcane the year I was married," she says. Asha has two sons and a daughter. Her daughter was eager to continue studies, but Asha and her husband married her off to a fabrication worker in Pune while she was still in Class 11.

"It is easy for you people to say that we must educate our girls, but you do not know what we have to face as parents of young girls – our biggest fear is their safety," says Asha, who migrated for sugarcane cutting with her husband and could neither take their daughter along nor leave her back at home.

Asha claims her son-in-law is just a couple of years older than her daughter.

Brides for sale

"A majority of families marry their daughters for security reasons, but many parents exploit their own daughters," says Ashok Tangade, chairperson of the Beed District Child Welfare Committee (CWC). In Shirur, 41 kilometres from Beed, a police case has been registered against the father and stepmother of a 15-year-old for forcefully marrying her off. The girl's mother and maternal uncle claim monetary transactions took place before the marriage.

Not all girls have a safe route home. A few years ago, 14-year-old Sheetal from Pimpal village in Beed wanted to stay home, go to school, and play with her friends. Married off by her parents to a local farmer, Dadasaheb Toge, she repeatedly returned to her parental home. When she resisted going back, her father, Prakash Bhange, strangled and smothered her to death in a sugarcane field, according to the police. Her father told authorities, "She wouldn't listen."

"Girls are being treated as a commodity in the

marriage market," observes Tangade. He adds, "You will find agents who identify poor parents with minor daughters. These agents bring marriage proposals and the grooms are ready to pay the agent and the girls' parents," says Tangade. He adds that some parents are even auctioning their girls. Caste takes a backseat in child marriages due to the shortage of brides caused by rampant female foeticide in the region.

The National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) puts Beed among the districts in Maharashtra with most cases of child marriages: 43.7% of women aged 20-24 were married before 18. Parbhani, a district in Marathwada, recorded the highest rate at 48%. Activists note that these numbers represent just the tip of the iceberg in Beed. While authorities have intervened to stop about 800 child marriages in recent years, filing formal cases remains difficult.

Maharashtra Women and Child Development Minister Aditi Tatkare said in the State Assembly in June this year that while child marriage rates have declined over the last five years in the State, the goal is to bring them below 10% within the next five years.

"In Maharashtra, we don't just act against the families involved, we register cases against everyone who enabled a child marriage: the priest, the band, the tent vendor, and the neighbours who attended. When an entire community is held accountable, an entire community becomes a safeguard," she said.

Noting that child marriages frequently occur in districts with heavy seasonal migration, she announced plans to establish childcare centres during migration periods to provide parents with safe spaces for their children. She emphasised, "Child marriage is not a tradition. It is a failure of systems, of awareness, and of protection."

Long, lonely battle

Political leaders in Beed and the Marathwada regions have popularised mass marriages, particularly during droughts or natural calamities. These ceremonies, say activists, provide an avenue for distressed masses to marry their minor daughters off.

Yogita, one of Suman's four daughters, is worried about both her niece Kirti and her own daughter. She wants to ensure that all the girls in the family finish school, but is concerned about the money. She wants independence, but is financially insecure. A daily wageer, she is currently unable to find work. "I have contacted social activists in Beed to help me complete my Class X examination. I am trying to get admission in school and appear for the exam," she says. Not everyone in the family is happy with her decision, especially her parents. They feel that she and their other daughters must go back to their homes and fulfil their responsibilities as wives and mothers.

Yogita resists. She has experienced how minor girls face mental and physical violence with nobody to complain to. In her village alone, there are young girls who have been beaten with hammers and iron rods by their husbands until they lost consciousness. "The only way to break this vicious cycle is to educate girls and make them stand on their own feet. This is not going to be easy, as girls will have to navigate their own way and fight their own battles," she says.

What Yogita is thinking, 15-year-old Rupali from Georai in Beed district has done. She was married forcibly to a 22-year-old man in Pune. After allegedly being tortured by her drunk husband and in-laws in the first week of her marriage, she approached a local NGO and was subsequently shifted to a hostel in Beed.

In February this year, she appeared for her Class 10 exam. She wants to study further and is now living with her parents. A local activist, requesting anonymity, said that government agencies, NGOs, and activists can only help her or any other girl to a certain extent. "There are hundreds of child marriages here and it is not possible to keep track of each one," he says.

For Rupali, the battle remains immensely difficult, devoid of support from parents and family members who remain deeply resentful that she chose to leave her husband. She does not have any children. Now, she fights for self-respect and a future that is different from the other women in her family.

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A family in Beed district weighs the future of its daughters amid poverty and seasonal migration. RADHESHYAM JADHAV

